

A PRACTICAL GUIDE TO PEOPLE AND PROBLEMS

SOMEHOW, I MANAGE

TOM MERTENS

KINDNESS · TRANSPARENCY · HUMOR · CURIOSITY

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Author's Note

WHERE THIS ADVICE ACTUALLY COMES FROM

The Only Guarantee in This Book

THERE'S A SONG from the late nineties — “Everybody’s Free to Wear Sunscreen,” built from a newspaper column the writer Mary Schmich wrote as a fictional commencement speech, later set to music by Baz Luhrmann — that opens with an admission I think about more than almost anything else I’ve read on the subject of giving advice. The gist of it, if you don’t already know it: sunscreen is the one tip the speaker can actually back up with science. Everything else that follows is just one person’s meandering experience, offered honestly, without the guarantee that comes with proven fact. I won’t fully quote it here, but I think about that opening every time I sit down to write another chapter of advice for you, because it’s the most honest way I know to introduce myself.

I am not a researcher. I have no clinical trial behind the claim that kindness works, no peer-reviewed study proving that humor defuses tension better than silence does. What I have is the same thing Mary Schmich had: years of meandering experience, most of it earned the hard way. So before you read another word of this book, I want to tell you where it actually came from, because it did not come from a pedestal.

I Have Hurt People I Didn't Mean to Hurt

SOMEWHERE IN THIS book, in a story about a struggling friend or a tense dinner or a joke that landed wrong, there is a version of me that got it right. What I haven’t told you yet is how many times I got it wrong first.

I have been so certain I was right in an argument that I steamrolled someone who was trying, badly, to tell me something true. I have made a joke at the wrong moment, to the wrong person, and watched the room go quiet in a way that told me everything I needed to know about how it landed. I have gone weeks without saying the honest thing because the honest thing was uncomfortable, and let a small problem calcify into a real one. None of that is a confession I'm making for sympathy. It's context. Every principle in this book exists because I violated it first and had to live with what that cost — a friendship, a family member's trust, a team's confidence, a version of myself I didn't like very much.

I Have Been on the Other Side of It, Too

THE REST OF what I know, I learned from the other direction — from managers who dismissed me before they'd heard me out, from colleagues who took credit for work I'd done and never once looked uncomfortable about it, from friends who drifted away after I said the wrong thing and never told me what it was, from a stretch early in my career when I dreaded walking into a building I used to like showing up to. Being hurt teaches you things being right never does. It's easy to write about trust from a comfortable chair. It's different to write it after spending a year without any.

I don't say any of this to earn credibility by way of suffering. Plenty of people have had it harder than I have, and plenty of people have turned less painful experiences into wiser lessons than I have. I say it because I don't want you to mistake this book for the work of someone who figured it all out early and is now generously reporting back. I am still figuring it out. I still get it wrong sometimes. The difference, if there is one, is that I've gotten it wrong often enough to notice the pattern, and I've tried to write down what I noticed before I forget it again.

Why I'm Telling You Anyway

IF THE ONLY people qualified to write about kindness were the people who'd never failed at it, this would be a very short book, written by no one. What actually qualifies a person to talk about how to treat people well is not a clean record.

It's having been on both ends of it enough times to know, in your body and not just your head, what the alternative costs.

So take what follows the way you'd take advice from anyone who's been in the room a long time and paid attention: not as instruction from above, but as one flawed, still-learning person telling you honestly what he's noticed. Some of it will land. Some of it won't fit your situation, your household, your workplace, your particular version of difficult. Keep what's useful. The rest, like most advice, was never going to be more reliable than the meandering experience it came from anyway.

The Nine-Year-Old in the Margins

ONE MORE THING before we begin. Most of the borrowed wisdom in this book comes from people who wrote it down: an emperor, a general, a psychiatrist, a salesman, and a few more besides. But the piece of advice I have leaned on hardest comes from a fictional nine-year-old in mismatched stockings, and I would rather admit that now than have you stumble across her halfway through. She has never held a job, never read a leadership book, and never once worried about looking foolish. That, as it turns out, is exactly why she is useful.

Introduction

WHY PEOPLE MATTER MOST

The Real Problem Nobody Talks About

DENNIS STOOD IN the corner of the boardroom, his hands clasped behind his back, watching a presentation he was supposed to be leading. Twenty years ago, he would have been in the ceiling tiles of this same room, pulling wire and cursing the architects who never left enough clearance. Now he was the operations director, and the people around the table were waiting for him to speak. The slide on the screen was his. The numbers were his. But the room felt like it belonged to someone else.

Here's what nobody says out loud: being good at what you do isn't the same as being good with the people around you. Plenty of people know their craft inside and out, keep their commitments, and still find themselves lonely at the table, or quietly left out of the rooms that matter most to them. They're not incompetent. They're not unkind. They're disconnected. And disconnected people, no matter how capable, eventually hit a ceiling they can't see and can't name.

I've watched brilliant technicians stall because they couldn't stand in a room with someone who disagreed with them. I've watched managers with impeccable spreadsheets lose teams because nobody wanted to be around them. I've watched fathers who provided everything except conversation, friends who kept score until nobody wanted to play, and neighbors who could fix any fence and never once knocked on a door. The problem was never their competence. It was their connection. They treated people like obstacles or afterthoughts, and the world responded in kind.

This book isn't about networking events or LinkedIn strategies. It's not about memorizing small-talk questions or forcing yourself to be outgoing. It's about something simpler and harder: becoming the kind of person other people are glad to have around, at work, at home, at the club, in the group chat. The kind of person who walks into a room and makes it feel a little easier. The kind of person who gets invited, not because they demanded it, but because people want them there.

If you have ever felt invisible in meetings, overlooked in your own family, or confused about why a friend stopped answering your messages, this book is for you. If you have ever wondered why the most capable person in the room keeps losing out to someone less qualified but warmer, this book is for you. And if you have ever wanted to be someone people actually enjoy being around, not someone they tolerate, this book is for you.

There's no trick here. No manipulation. No pretending to be someone you're not. What I want to share is a way of moving through the world, and the people in it, that feels natural, human, and true. It's built on five things: being kind, being transparent, communicating and sharing, using humor, and a fifth that keeps the other four from staying good intentions, which is looking for the way through before you list the reasons not to. That's the foundation; everything else grows out of it.

The Simple Truth That Changed Everything

FOR YEARS, I believed the story that most workplaces tell, and plenty of families quietly tell too: keep your head down, do your part, and let the work speak for itself. So I kept my head down. I did the job. And I waited. But the work didn't speak — or if it did, nobody was listening. What got people's attention wasn't the quality of my output. It was the quality of my presence.

The shift started small. A technician asked me a question I had answered a hundred times, and instead of sighing and pointing to the manual, I walked over and showed him, making a joke about how the manual was written by someone who had clearly never held a wrench. He laughed. He relaxed. He learned. And the next time he had a question, he came to me without hesitation.

That was the first crack in my old belief system. The work mattered, but so did the way I made people feel while doing it. Kindness wasn't a soft add-on; it was the thing that got the work done faster and better. Transparency wasn't a risk; it was a shortcut to trust. Sharing credit and information didn't diminish me; it multiplied what came back. And humor — real, human, self-aware humor — turned tense moments into shared ones.

Over time, I started to see a pattern. The people who got along with others, at work and everywhere else, didn't do it by being pushovers or politicians. They did it by being genuinely decent humans, consistently and on purpose. They told the truth without being cruel. They helped without keeping score. They laughed without cutting anyone down. And in return, people wanted to be around them, wanted to work with them, live near them, wanted to see them succeed.

This isn't a secret formula. It's not a hack. It's an approach to being with people that I learned slowly, through years of getting it wrong and occasionally getting it right. The chapters ahead will walk through why poor relationships cost so much, how kindness and transparency and humor actually work, how to meet obstacles with curiosity instead of a list of reasons to stop, and how to practice all of it every day, even when things go wrong. But the core message is the same in every chapter: people matter most. If you can learn to get along with people, everything else, in your career and outside it, gets easier.

I'm not going to promise you a corner office in ninety days. But I can promise you this: if you start treating the people around you with genuine kindness, radical honesty, generous sharing, and a little bit of humor, and if you start meeting problems with curiosity instead of dread, your work life, and the rest of your life, will change. Not because you manipulated anyone, but because you became the person others are glad to see.

A Girl, a Cake, and No Recipe

PIPPY LONGSTOCKING STOOD in her kitchen with flour on her nose and no idea what she was doing. She had braided red hair that stuck straight out on both sides. She had mismatched stockings, one brown and one black. She had a cake to bake and absolutely zero experience baking one.

No recipe. No measuring cups that matched. No adult leaning over her shoulder saying, “That’s not how you do it.” Just a girl, a bowl, and a wild idea that a cake could happen anyway.

Most of us would have looked at that kitchen and seen a list of problems. No recipe means I can’t start. No proper tools means it won’t turn out. No experience means why bother trying. Pippi looked at the same kitchen and saw something completely different. She saw a cake that didn’t know yet that she had never made one.

That’s the spirit behind the fifth principle in this book, and the one that makes the other four possible. Not the confidence of someone who has done it a thousand times. The confidence of someone who has never done it once and decides that’s not a reason to stop.

I first encountered Pippi’s logic as a child and forgot it, the way most of us forget the things we knew before the world told us to be sensible. Years later it came back to me in a moment when I needed it. I had a decision in front of me that I had no business making, no training for, and no map to follow. And somewhere in the back of my head, a nine-year-old girl in mismatched stockings whispered the line that changed everything.

I never did it before, so I think I can.

Read that again. It isn’t a typo, and it isn’t a slogan. It’s a completely different way of facing the unknown, and once you’ve heard it, you can’t unhear it.

I should be honest about something here, since honesty is one of the things this book is built on. Pippi never actually says that line. It turns up on mugs, posters and greeting cards all over Europe, but it isn’t in any of Astrid Lindgren’s books, and the official Astrid Lindgren website lists it among the popular misquotes attributed to her. The closest thing comes in *Pippi Goes on Board*, when Pippi marches into a shop wanting to buy a piano and Tommy asks whether she can even play one. Her answer is pure Pippi: how could she possibly know, when she’s never tried? She adds, for good measure, that she’s never had a piano to try it on, and that playing the piano without one takes an awful lot of practice. The kitchen and the cake are my own picture of her, too, rather than a scene from the books. So the famous sentence is a paraphrase — a kind of folk distillation of the

way she moves through the world. I've kept it anyway, because it captures her spirit exactly, and because the real line says the same thing: you can't know you can't until you've tried.

You might wonder what a girl with a horse on her porch has to do with meetings, family dinners and difficult people. Quite a lot, it turns out. Kindness, transparency, sharing and humor tell you how to treat the people around you. They don't tell you what to do when the task itself looks impossible, or when everyone around you has decided something can't be done. That's where Pippi comes in. The second half of this book is hers, and by the end I hope you'll find a little of her in you.

The Key Insight: Inexperience Is an Advantage

WE TREAT INEXPERIENCE like a debt, something you have to pay off before you're allowed to try. Get the degree, get the certification, get the ten thousand hours, and then, only then, you can begin.

Pippi had it backwards on purpose. She treated inexperience like a permission slip. No recipe means no rules about what a cake should be. No training means no habits telling her what's impossible. No track record means nothing to protect and nothing to lose.

Think about what that really means. When you've never done something, you haven't yet learned what's supposed to be hard about it. You haven't absorbed the assumptions that the veterans carry around like heavy luggage. You're free in a way that experts aren't.

Experts are great at solving problems they've seen before. They're terrible at seeing a problem fresh, because their whole value is built on knowing the known. When something genuinely new shows up, the expert often reaches for the closest old answer and misses the thing that's actually in front of them.

The beginner has no closest old answer. The beginner has to look. And looking is where opportunities live. There's a second part to this insight, and it's just as important. Sometimes the right move is to go the opposite direction of what everyone sensible is doing — not out of rebellion, but out of clarity. If the crowd is all running one way, and you actually stop to look at the terrain, you might notice the crowd is running toward a cliff.

Sometimes you have to go the opposite direction — and that starts with believing that never having done it before is a strange, underrated kind of qualification.

What This Book Will Do for You

THERE ARE PLENTY of books about leadership, communication, and office politics, and plenty more about relationships. Many of them are full of theories, frameworks, and jargon that sound impressive in a seminar but fall apart the moment you try to use them with a real human being across a real table. This book is different. I'm not a researcher or a consultant. I'm someone who has spent years in the trenches of actual workplaces and actual families — noisy, messy, imperfect places where people are tired and stressed and sometimes hard to like.

What you'll find here is practical and human, and it comes in two parts. Part One is about people. We will look honestly at what poor relationships quietly cost, build a framework around the four principles I've lived by — kindness, transparency, communication and sharing, and humor — get into the daily practice, talk about what to do when things go wrong, and zoom out to who you become, not just what you do. Part Two is about problems, and it belongs to a fifth principle I've come to call Pippi's principle: the habit of looking for the way through instead of the reasons not to. It covers why our minds default to obstacles, how to flip that default, a few small ways of looking that help, what to do on the days it doesn't work, and what it looks like when it becomes part of who you are.

Along the way, you'll hear stories — some mine, some from people I've worked with, some from people I've watched fail and then learn. These aren't polished case studies. They're real moments from real workplaces, kitchens and living rooms, the kind you've probably lived through yourself more times than you can count.

You won't need a personality transplant. If you're shy, you can still be kind; if you're blunt, you can still be transparent; if you're serious, you can still use humor. The goal isn't to become someone else, but a better version of who you already are, in every place where you spend your days.

You'll notice, here and there, that the ideas in this book aren't new. Some of them are almost impossibly old. Every time I tried to explain what actually works

between people, I found that someone had said it long before me, and usually better: a Chinese general, two Stoics — one a Roman emperor, the other a freed slave — a psychiatrist who survived the camps, a plainspoken teacher from Missouri, the Gospels, and a philosophy built on taking it easy. They turn up throughout, usually just when I need them.

And there's one more, whom you've already met: a fictional nine-year-old in mismatched stockings, by far the least respectful of the group.

I wrote this book because I believe the world is starving for people who simply treat each other well. Not in a fluffy, inspirational-poster kind of way — in a concrete, daily, get-through-the-week-together kind of way. If you want to be that person, or if you're already partway there and want to go further, keep going. First, a word on how to use this book.

How to Read This Book

YOU CAN READ this book in two ways, and both work. The first way is straight through, letting the ideas stack up so that by the end you have the full picture. The second way is to jump to the part that matches the trouble you're in right now and come back later for the rest.

If the trouble is between you and another person, start with Part One. If the trouble is a stuck project, a decision you keep avoiding, or a voice in your head listing reasons not to, start with Part Two. If something has already gone wrong, a blown meeting, an argument at the dinner table, a rejection, a joke that landed badly, go straight to Chapter 4 for the people side or Chapter 9 for the rest. There's no wrong door into this book.

One request, though, and it's the only one. Don't just read. Try something. Pick one small thing that you've been meaning to do but haven't done, whether it's a conversation with a coworker or a sibling, or a project you've never attempted, and do it this week, badly if you have to. The ideas in this book only become real when they move from your head into your hands.

You don't need to be the kind of person who has always been brave. You don't need credentials, permission, or perfect timing. You just need to be willing to stand in the kitchen with flour on your nose and give the cake a shot.

Turn the page. Bring your kindness and your curiosity. The first thing we need to understand is what it actually costs when we get it wrong.

PART ONE

People

Part One is about the people in your life, at work and everywhere else. It covers what disconnection quietly costs, the four principles I have leaned on — kindness, transparency, sharing and humor — how to practice them on an ordinary Tuesday, how to repair things when they break, and who you become along the way.

CHAPTER 1

The Quiet Cost of Getting It Wrong

WHAT DISCONNECTION QUIETLY TAKES FROM US

The Meeting Nobody Wants to Attend

PRIYA SAT ALONE in the glass-walled conference room on the third floor, the Austin sun cutting through the blinds in long slashes across the table. The code review had ended twenty minutes ago, but she was still there, scrolling back through the Slack thread like she might find something different on the fourth read. Her suggestion about the database migration — the one she'd spent two hours preparing for, the one that would've saved the team three days of rework — had been buried under a dozen other messages. Not rejected. Not argued with. Just... passed over. Like she'd never said anything at all.

Nobody wants to admit how much this kind of thing stings. We tell ourselves it's just work, just a meeting, just a thread that scrolled past. But the tightness in her chest was real. The urge to type something sharp and then delete it was real. The quiet voice asking why she bothered speaking up at all — that was real too. This is the meeting nobody wants to attend: not the one on the calendar, but the one that happens inside your own head afterward.

Here's the part we don't talk about enough. Poor relationships don't just waste time — they drain something deeper. They drain the energy you'd otherwise spend solving problems, the creativity you'd bring to a whiteboard, the enthusiasm that gets you out of bed and into the car with some sense of possibility. When relationships go wrong, even mildly wrong, everything gets heavier. Not because the tasks changed, but because the space you do them in got smaller.

I've watched talented people fade out of rooms where they should have been leading. Not because they couldn't do the job — they could do it better than most. But somewhere along the way, the dynamics around them turned sour. They got passed over in meetings like Priya. They got left off threads. They got assigned the work nobody wanted, not because they deserved it, but because it was easier to give it to the person nobody would complain about losing a day with. I have seen the same thing at kitchen tables, where the family member who always gets the same joke made at their expense slowly stops coming to dinner.

The blame usually lands on the circumstances. The project was badly managed. The deadline was unrealistic. Or, at home: it has been a busy year, we live too far apart, everyone is tired. And sure, those things happen. But the deeper problem is often quieter and harder to see: the relationships that never got built, the trust that never got earned, the small disconnections that piled up until the only thing left was friction.

This chapter is about that hidden cost. Not the dramatic blowups that get people fired or end friendships, but the slow leak that makes every day a little harder than it needs to be. The cost you pay in energy, confidence, and opportunity when the people around you feel like obstacles instead of allies. It's a cost nobody puts on a spreadsheet, but everybody pays. Before we get to what to do about it — and we will — I want you to see clearly what you're already losing. Not so you feel worse, but so you know exactly what's at stake. Because once you see the real price of disconnection, the choice to do something different stops being optional. It becomes the only move that makes sense.

The Invisible Wall Between You and Everyone Else

THERE'S A MOMENT in a lot of relationships, at work and at home, where things shift. It's never announced. No one sends an email saying, "Effective today, communication will break down." But you can feel it. The hallway conversations get shorter. The replies get slower. The little questions that used to get asked out loud now get swallowed, because asking feels like an imposition. You're still on the same team, or in the same family, technically. But there's a wall now, and it's building itself brick by brick.

The wall almost never starts with a big betrayal. It starts small. A message left on read for a day. A birthday call that quietly became a text. A meeting where someone's idea got claimed by someone else. A joke that landed wrong and never got cleaned up. A conversation where one person walked away thinking everything was fine and the other person walked away stung. Each one of those moments adds a brick. Not much on its own. But bricks stack.

What makes the wall so dangerous is that it's invisible to the people who haven't hit it. You can sit at the same table, look at the same numbers, agree on the same plan — and still be completely unaware that the person across from you has stopped wanting to help you. The wall doesn't show up in status updates, and nobody flags it at a family gathering either. It just quietly separates you from the people you need most.

Priya's wall started with something tiny. A code review where her pickier comments got interpreted as criticism instead of care. She meant them as help — here's how this could be stronger — but the message that landed was different. The developer on the other end started pushing back on everything she suggested, and after a while, she stopped suggesting. Then she stopped commenting. Then she stopped reviewing his code at all unless she absolutely had to. The wall was up, and neither of them had ever actually talked about it.

That's the thing about these walls. They get built by interpretation, not intention. You think you're being careful; they think you're being cold. You think you're being direct; they think you're being harsh. You think you're giving them space; they think you've given up on them. The wall doesn't care what you meant. It only cares what got received.

The same wall goes up between people who share a last name. Hannah and her brother Joel had not had a real conversation in three years. It began with the arrangements after their father's funeral, when Joel made a decision about the house without asking her, and Hannah, who had done most of the caregiving, heard it as a verdict on all of it. Joel thought he was sparing her one more chore. Neither of them said so. Each birthday brought a shorter text. By the time their mother turned eighty they could talk about the weather, the traffic and the food, and about nothing else at all. Nothing had been said that could not be undone. That was the trouble. Nothing had been said.

There's an old observation, written by Marcus Aurelius in the journal he kept purely for himself — later published as *Meditations* — that most of what troubles us isn't the event but the story we quietly attach to it. He wasn't thinking about code reviews or family group chats — he was thinking about senators and soldiers — but the mechanism is identical. Priya didn't get hurt by a delayed reply. She got hurt by what she decided the delayed reply meant about her. Hannah didn't get hurt by a decision about a house. She got hurt by what she decided it said about the years she had spent caring for their father. The developer didn't get defensive because of her comments. He got defensive because of the story he told himself about what her comments meant about him. Neither of them was wrong to feel something. They were just both reacting to an interpretation, not an event, and neither one ever checked the interpretation against reality.

Once the wall is up, everything gets filtered through it. Constructive feedback sounds like criticism. A simple question sounds like a challenge. Silence sounds like rejection. You stop giving each other the benefit of the doubt, because doubt is all there is. The same words that would've been fine six months ago now land like accusations. The wall isn't just between you — it's inside the way you hear everything they say.

The cost of the wall isn't just emotional. It's practical. Work slows down because questions don't get asked. Holidays get stiff because everyone is being careful. Mistakes slip through because people stop checking each other's work. Good ideas die in drafts because nobody wants to share anything with someone they don't trust to receive it well. The wall doesn't just separate people — it separates a team, or a family, from its own potential.

The Fear That Keeps Us Guarded

MOST PEOPLE DON'T walk into a room thinking about how to build walls. They walk in trying to survive. The fear that keeps us guarded isn't paranoia — it's pattern recognition. Somewhere along the line, most of us learned that opening up carries risk. Share an idea and it might get stolen. Admit a mistake and it might get used against you. Say how much you care and someone might call it naive, or worse, take it for granted. So we armor up.

The armor looks different for everyone. For some people it's silence — keep your head down, do your work, don't volunteer anything you don't have to. For others it's aggressive competence — be so good at your job that nobody can afford to mess with you. For others it's strategic distance — be friendly enough to not seem hostile, but never let anyone close enough to hurt you. All of it is self-protection. All of it works, sort of. All of it costs more than it saves.

I've worked with people who were genuinely talented but completely walled off. One guy — let's call him Ray — could do the work of three people and never made a single friend in five years. He kept his head down, never shared credit, never asked for help, never let anyone see him struggle. He thought he was protecting himself from office politics. What he was actually doing was making himself easy to overlook, easy to misjudge, and easy to work around. The self-protection worked, until it didn't.

I have known a Ray at home, too: a neighbor who kept the tidiest garden on the street for thirty years and could not have told you the name of the family three doors down. Same armor, different address.

Being guarded changes how people see you. They can't read you, so they fill in the blanks with their own stories. If you never share anything personal, they assume you're cold. If you never disagree, they assume you don't care. If you never ask for help, they assume you think you're better than them. The armor you wear to protect yourself becomes the cage people see you in.

And the guarded person isn't free either. There's a specific kind of exhaustion that comes from constantly monitoring yourself — editing what you say, calculating what you reveal, scanning for threats in casual conversation. It's a full-time job on top of your full-time job. By the end of the week, you're not tired from the work. You're tired from the vigilance.

Viktor Frankl, the psychiatrist who lived through the Holocaust, spent the rest of his career arguing for a single idea, laid out in *Man's Search for Meaning*: that almost everything can be taken from a person, but not the freedom to choose how they respond to what happens to them. That is an enormous claim, forged in circumstances most of us will thankfully never know. But the smaller, everyday-sized version of it is worth sitting with. Ray's armor was not forced on him by the world. It was a response he kept choosing, day after day, year after year, because at

some point it had felt like the only safe option. It is worth asking, honestly, whether the guardedness you are carrying right now is a response to something happening to you today, or a response you have simply kept choosing out of habit, long after the original threat passed.

Maybe the biggest irony is this: the fear that keeps us guarded is usually fear of being hurt, being rejected, being judged. But the guarding itself is what creates the distance that leads to being hurt, rejected, and judged. You hold back, so people don't know you. They don't know you, so they don't trust you. They don't trust you, so they don't include you. You see the exclusion and think — see? I was right to protect myself. The loop closes. The wall gets higher.

Breaking that loop requires something uncomfortable: accepting that openness carries risk, and choosing it anyway. Not all at once, not with everyone, but enough to let a few people actually see you. The alternative — staying fully armored — doesn't keep you safe. It just keeps you alone, inside a life you paid for with more than your time.

What We Tell Ourselves About “Difficult” People

EVERY WORKPLACE, EVERY family and every group of friends has at least one of them. The person who's impossible. The one who never listens. The one who always has to win. The one who makes every meeting, or every holiday dinner, longer than it needs to be. We swap stories about them at lunch, roll our eyes at their name in an email thread, and mentally prepare ourselves before every interaction. They're just difficult. That's the story. And we've accepted it as fact.

But here's something I've learned from watching years of people dynamics: the story we tell about difficult people is usually more about us than them. We decide someone is difficult, and then we start treating them like they're difficult. We brace ourselves before conversations, which makes the conversation awkward. We assume bad intent, which makes us defensive. We stop listening, which makes them more insistent. They respond to our guardedness with their own. And the story — see, they're impossible — confirms itself.

That's not to say some people aren't genuinely hard to be around. They are. But the label of difficult is like a wall you build around both of you. It gives you

permission to stop trying, to stop being curious, to stop looking for what's underneath the behavior. It's the easiest story to tell, and the most expensive.

Priya had a difficult person in her orbit. His name was Dan, and he was loud in meetings, quick to interrupt, and always positioned his ideas as the obvious choice. She told herself he was a jerk, a blowhard, someone to be managed rather than understood. The story gave her some relief — the problem was him, not her. But it also kept her from ever asking: why does he feel the need to be loud? What is he afraid will happen if he isn't? Those questions would've been uncomfortable. It was easier to just keep rolling her eyes.

It is rarely different at home. Every family has its Dan: the uncle who turns every gathering into a debate, the in-law who corrects the way you load the dishwasher. We swap stories about them in the car on the way home, and the stories get better every year, and nobody ever asks the uncle a single question.

Dale Carnegie gave a piece of advice in *How to Win Friends and Influence People*, over eighty years old now and still handed out in sales training and management workshops alike, that comes down to something almost too simple to take seriously: the only reliable way to influence someone is to see the situation genuinely from their side, not just well enough to argue against it. Most of us do the opposite. We build the strongest possible case for why we're right and the other person is being difficult, and we call that understanding. It isn't. Understanding means being able to explain Dan's behavior the way Dan himself would explain it — not the way that makes you feel better about disliking him.

There is an old rule of thumb for exactly this, known as Hanlon's razor: never attribute to malice what is adequately explained by stupidity. I prefer the gentler reading, which swaps in carelessness, distraction and exhaustion. Most of the people who hurt us are not plotting anything. They are tired, afraid, behind on three things, or simply not thinking about us at all, which is its own small sting but a very different thing from an attack. The delayed reply, the forgotten invitation, the comment that landed like a slap: nine times out of ten the honest explanation is dull. Assuming malice feels safer, because it gives you a villain and a story. Assuming carelessness costs you the story, but it gives you back the relationship. And on the rare occasion you are wrong, and there really was intent, you will find that out soon enough, and you will have lost nothing by asking first.

There's a deeper habit hiding underneath the difficult-person story, and it's worth naming honestly: the quiet assumption that you'd handle things better than they do, that you're somehow above the reaction. Viktor Frankl, writing about what he witnessed both in the concentration camps and later in his psychiatric practice, made an observation that has stayed with me: worry and distress behave like a gas released into a room. It doesn't matter how big or small the room is — the gas expands to fill whatever space it's given. A person facing a life-threatening diagnosis and a person facing a missed promotion can both be, in that moment, completely filled by the feeling. The size of the container doesn't determine how real the fullness is. A kid will cry like the world is ending because a scoop of candy fell on the sidewalk, and it's tempting to call that ridiculous. It isn't. For a four-year-old, that candy was the whole world for that moment, and their container is smaller, so it fills faster. Dan, loud and interrupting in every meeting, is carrying a container you've never seen the inside of.

This is where I try to catch myself before I ever get to difficult in the first place: you are not superior to the people whose reactions you don't understand. You've maybe just read the right book, heard the right idea at the right moment, or had someone hand you advice that this person never got the chance to receive. That's not virtue. That's luck with good timing. It's close to the same idea Jesus is recorded making, in the Sermon on the Mount, about noticing the speck in someone else's eye while ignoring the plank in your own — most of what we call someone else's flaw is easier to spot than the larger version of it we're carrying ourselves. None of that excuses bad behavior. It just means holding your own reaction to their reaction a little more loosely, because you have no real idea what's already filling their room.

The stories we tell about difficult people also shape how we show up around them. When you've decided someone is a problem, every interaction becomes a negotiation with an opponent. You stop sharing information freely. You stop assuming good faith. You start looking for the trap in everything they say. And they feel it. They feel their guard go up in response. What could've been a workable relationship becomes a permanent standoff, all because the story made it impossible for either side to move.

Changing the story requires something that feels almost irresponsible at first: instead of asking, what's wrong with them, ask, what might be going on for them. What deadline are they under that I can't see? What pressure did they walk in with this morning? What did they learn about trust in their last job, their last family dynamic, their last failure? None of that excuses bad behavior. But it opens the door to understanding — and understanding is the only thing that has ever actually turned a difficult person into a person.

Here's the quiet cost of sticking with the difficult-person story: you stay stuck. You stay right, and you stay stuck. The other person picks up your judgment, and they dig in harder. The story you told to protect yourself from them becomes the very thing that keeps the friction alive. You don't have to become friends with every difficult person in your life. But you do have to stop feeding yourself a story that guarantees the struggle never ends.

The Ripple Effect of One Bad Interaction

ONE TENSE EXCHANGE on a Tuesday morning can shape an entire week. That's not an exaggeration — it's mechanics. You snap at someone you love, or they snap at you, or there's a conversation where the tension is so thick nobody says what they actually think. Then you walk out of that room carrying it. The conversation replays in your head on the drive home. You mention it to your partner over dinner. You wake up at 3 a.m. running through what you should have said. One interaction. Days of fallout.

But the ripple doesn't stop with you. The person you snapped at carries it too. Maybe they mention it to a friend. Maybe they're sharper with the people who report to them, or with their own children, that afternoon. Maybe they sit in their car in their driveway for an extra five minutes, not ready to bring that energy home. The tension moves through the system like a stone dropped in a pond — you only see the first splash, but the ripples reach every shore.

There's a specific kind of gathering I've seen too many times, whether it's a project meeting or a family lunch: everyone arrives with good intentions, and everyone leaves with a grudge. It starts with one small thing — someone talks over someone else, someone's idea gets dismissed without real consideration, someone's effort gets ignored. Then the rest of the meeting gets filtered through

that first sting. People get quiet. People get petty. People start watching the clock. The gathering that should've moved things forward becomes the thing that moved everything backward.

Then there's the ripple that goes inward, into the work itself. When Priya's suggestion got buried in that Slack thread, it didn't just hurt her feelings. It changed what she did with her later ideas. She started second-guessing herself. She started waiting for someone else to say what she was thinking, so she wouldn't have to risk being ignored again. She started doing the work of three people with the confidence of half a person. That's the real cost — not the momentary sting, but the lingering caution that follows.

Bad interactions also ripple sideways, into the people who witness them. When someone watches a colleague, or a sibling, get undermined or disrespected without pushback, a small calculation happens in the back of their mind: that could be me. So they start protecting themselves. They stop being the one who suggests new ideas, because they saw what happened to the last person who stuck their neck out. The one bad interaction becomes a lesson for everyone watching — not a lesson about what happened, but a lesson about what to avoid.

The hardest part of the ripple effect is that you can't see it in real time. You have one sharp conversation and think, well, that was bad, but it's over. It's not over. It's moving through the team, through the house, through the week, through the way people show up tomorrow. Every unkind moment has a shadow that reaches farther than the moment itself. The opposite is also true — one genuine act of care ripples too — but for now, I want you to feel the weight of the negative version, because that's what this chapter is about.

If you add up all the ripples — the lost sleep, the guarded conversations, the second-guessing, the good ideas that never get shared, the slow erosion of trust — you start to see the real price of disconnection. It's not one big cost you can budget for. It's a thousand small leaks, every day, draining everyone's energy, yours included. And the wild part is, most of it never needed to happen. The interactions that cause so much damage are almost never about the thing they seem to be about. They're about the moment — the tension, the misunderstanding, the cracked relationship — that made ordinary life feel like a battleground instead of a shared effort.

CHAPTER 2

*Kindness, Transparency, Humor, and
Sharing*

FOUR PRINCIPLES FOR BEING WITH PEOPLE

Why Kindness Isn't Weakness

DEREK HAD SPENT fifteen years believing that nice guys finish last in sales. He'd built a career on being the sharpest voice in the room, the guy who asked the tough questions and never let a competitor get comfortable. When a junior rep on his team named Camille landed a major client through what Derek privately called "hand-holding," he felt the old itch to dismiss it. Then he watched what happened over the next six months. Camille's client renewed early, referred two more accounts, and asked for her specifically when a contract hit a rough patch. Derek had won plenty of deals, but he'd never once had a client request him by name when things got hard.

The thing about kindness is that most people mistake it for passivity. They picture someone who says yes to everything, apologizes too much, and never pushes back. That's not kindness. That's fear wearing a friendly mask. Real kindness looks like telling a friend the truth about a plan before they bet their savings on it. It looks like giving a struggling teammate, or a teenager, the specific feedback they need to improve, even when the conversation is uncomfortable. It looks like making sure the quiet person at the table, whether that is a meeting or a birthday dinner, gets heard when the loud voices start talking over them. None of that is soft. All of it takes backbone.

I've seen technically brilliant people stall out because they treated every interaction as a transaction. They knew their stuff cold, but they made every conversa-

tion feel like a negotiation. Kindness flips that dynamic. When you genuinely want the person across from you to succeed, they can feel it.

Dale Carnegie, a largely self-taught teacher, built his entire career — and eventually *How to Win Friends and Influence People*, one of the most widely read books ever written about people — around a single observation: you can make more genuine allies in two months of becoming truly interested in other people than in two years of trying to get other people interested in you. It sounds almost too plain to matter, and that is exactly why most people skip past it. Derek had spent fifteen years trying to get clients interested in him — in his expertise, his sharpness, his win rate. Camille skipped that step entirely. She got interested in them. The renewal, the referrals, the client asking for her by name — none of that was a sales technique. It was the entirely predictable result of a person who had actually paid attention.

And here's what the cynics miss: people work harder for someone who wants them to win. They volunteer information earlier. They flag problems before they become emergencies. They pick up the phone when you call, even years later, because they remember how you made them feel at 3 p.m. on a random Tuesday when they were drowning and you stopped to help.

A young engineer once asked me why I was always nice to the facilities staff, the security guards, the people most managers walked past without a glance. The same question could be asked about the waiter, the school caretaker, the neighbor who keeps to himself. The answer was simple: they're people. They see everything. They know who's genuine and who's performing. And when you need something done fast — a room rearranged, a badge replaced, a package tracked down — the relationships you've built with kindness pay off in ways no org chart can predict. But that's not even the main reason. The main reason is that being kind to one person, even when no one's watching, shapes who you become. Every small act of decency makes the next one easier, until eventually kindness isn't a strategy. It's just how you move through the day.

There's an old teaching that gets at exactly this, even for people who've never set foot in a church. Jesus, in one of the more quoted passages in the Gospel of Matthew, described people who fed the hungry and looked after the sick without realizing they were doing anything significant at all — and the point of the story

was that however you treat the person with the least power or status in the room, that's the treatment that actually counts. Strip away the theology and you're left with the same thing Sun Tzu, Marcus Aurelius, and a century of research on how people treat each other keep circling back to: character shows up most clearly in the interactions that don't seem to matter. Nobody's grading how you treat the security guard. That's exactly why it's the truest test available.

Kindness also creates a kind of safety, and safety brings out the best in people. When people stop worrying about whether you'll make them feel stupid for asking a question, they start asking the questions that actually matter. When they know you won't throw them under the bus for a mistake, they own mistakes faster and fix them sooner. I've watched teams transform just because someone stopped treating every interaction as a dominance contest and started treating people like allies. I've watched a family dinner change the same way, the year a father stopped correcting everyone's stories and started listening to them. The results improve, the loyalty improves, and the daily experience improves. But it starts with the choice to be kind when you don't have to be.

Does kindness mean never getting angry? Never holding a line? No. Some of the kindest things I've ever done were also the hardest — letting go of someone who was destroying a team, telling a friend I couldn't lend money again, saying no to a project that would have burned out a junior colleague, pushing back against a client who treated my people badly. Kindness and strength aren't opposites. They're the same thing pointed in the right direction. The difference is intent. You can hold a hard line while respecting the person across from you. You can deliver bad news without enjoying it. You can say no without making someone feel small.

If you're reading this as someone with no authority over anyone — a technician, an individual contributor, the younger sibling, the friend who never wanted to organize anything — understand that kindness is leverage. It's how you build influence without a title. It's how you get people to loop you into decisions before they're made, to seek your opinion before you offer it, to trust you with what matters. You don't need authority to be kind. You just need to start.

Transparency Without Oversharing

THERE'S A MOMENT in nearly every day when someone says "How's it going?" and you have to decide: tell the truth or give the polite answer. Most people default to the polite answer because it feels safer. I'm fine. Everything's on track. No concerns. But the polite answer has a cost. It creates distance. People can tell when you're holding back, and they respond by holding back too. Pretty soon you're in a room, or a marriage, full of people performing fine while nothing is actually fine, and everything suffers because nobody wants to be the first one to admit there's a problem.

I learned this the hard way during a period when I was newer in a leadership role and felt pressure to project confidence at all times. I hid my uncertainties because I thought that was what leaders did. What actually happened was that my team sensed something was off, couldn't figure out what, and started filling in the blanks with their own anxious stories. They assumed the worst — budget cuts, layoffs, a failing project — because I hadn't given them the real story.

It happens at home, too. A parent who hides a worry about money "to protect the children" rarely protects them. Children are excellent detectives, and they fill the gaps with stories far scarier than the truth.

There's a simple test I use now: does sharing this help the other person understand what's happening, make a better decision, or feel less alone? If yes, share it. If no, keep it to yourself. Your coworker doesn't need to know about the argument you had with your spouse, but they probably do need to know that you're stretched thin this week and might need help with the quarterly report. Your spouse doesn't need every anxious thought about the mortgage at midnight, but they do need to know you're worried. Your direct reports don't need to know every doubt running through your head, but they do need to know when their work is at risk of being cut so they can advocate for it. Transparency is about giving people the information they need before they have to ask for it, especially when that information is uncomfortable.

The oversharing boundary is real, and crossing it costs you credibility. Nobody wants to hear about your medical history in a status meeting. Nobody wants to be your therapist. But most people err way too far in the other direction. They share

nothing, assume everyone else has it together, and then wonder why they feel isolated. The sweet spot is honesty about the things that affect other people: be honest about the project, the plan, the relationship, the conflict. Be honest about what you don't know. Be honest when you've changed your mind. People forgive a lot of things, but they don't forgive being managed like they can't handle the truth.

Carnegie, who spent his career studying what actually earns trust between people, had a blunt piece of advice for moments exactly like this one: if you are wrong, or uncertain, or in over your head, say so quickly and plainly, before someone else has to say it for you. Most of us do the opposite instinctively. We hedge. We wait. We hope the problem resolves itself before anyone notices we didn't have it handled. It rarely does, and the waiting is what erodes trust, not the admission itself. When I finally sat down and said, "Look, I'm not sure about this decision and I need your input," the relief in the room was instant. It wasn't weakness. It was invitation. I was inviting them to be partners instead of spectators.

Transparency also builds trust at scale. When you're open about your reasoning, people don't have to guess at your motives. They can disagree with your conclusion and still trust the process that got you there. When you're open about your mistakes, people stop hiding theirs. When you're open about what you need from others, they actually have a chance to give it to you. None of this requires you to become an open book about every personal detail. It just requires you to stop pretending that life requires a mask.

The hardest part of transparency is doing it before a crisis forces you to. The easiest time to tell someone bad news is today. The most expensive time is next month, when the problem has compounded and they find out from someone else. Build the habit of early honesty now, when the stakes are low, and you'll have the muscle memory when the stakes get high.

The Humor That Heals — and the Humor That Hurts

HUMOR IS THE fastest shortcut to trust I've ever found, and also the fastest way to blow it. The difference comes down to one thing: who's the target? Humor that heals builds people up. It defuses tension, makes the work feel lighter, and re-

minds everyone that we're all just humans trying to do a strange job called living. Humor that hurts usually has a victim — someone's embarrassment, someone's insecurity, someone's mistake — and it leaves a mark that lasts far longer than the laugh.

Where humor goes wrong is when it punches down. Making fun of someone's accent, someone's appearance, someone's mistake in a way that singles them out, someone's cultural background — that's not humor, that's aggression with a laugh track. It destroys trust instantly and it's almost impossible to recover from. The damage isn't just to the person targeted. Everyone else in the room learns something too: that you're the kind of person who might turn on them next. One sarcastic comment about someone's weight or intelligence can undo months of relationship-building. The joke isn't worth the cost, ever.

There's also the subtler failure mode of using humor as a way to avoid real issues. Some people deflect every serious conversation with a joke, and it eventually becomes exhausting. They think they're keeping things light, but what they're actually doing is refusing to engage. If the people around you are dealing with a real problem and your response is always a quip, people stop bringing you real problems. They learn that you can't be trusted with weight. Use humor to open doors, not to close them.

Dudeism — a laid-back, modern take on some much older ideas about flowing with life instead of fighting it — has a favorite insight here: most tension in a room is optional — you can match it, or you can just not. The best humor works the same way. It doesn't escalate the moment. It just declines to take the moment quite as seriously as everyone's shoulders suggest they're taking it. That's a different move than deflecting a real problem. Deflection avoids the issue. Good humor just refuses to let the issue get bigger than it actually is.

The best everyday humor is observational. It names the absurdity of a situation without making anyone in the room the butt of the joke. "Well, that meeting could have been an email" is funny because everyone's felt it, and it's aimed at no one in particular. "This project has more layers than my aunt's lasagna," or "Every family has one dish nobody likes and everybody brings" works because it's specific, warm, and a little self-deprecating. The more you can point at the situation rather than the person, the safer and more effective your humor will be.

If you're not naturally funny, don't force it. Attempted humor that falls flat is worse than no humor at all. But almost everyone has some version of levity they can access — a wry observation, a playful tone, a willingness to laugh at themselves. Start small. Notice what makes the people around you genuinely laugh without wincing. Build on that. Humor is like any other tool: the more you practice with it, the better you get, and the more you understand when to set it down.

Sharing the Credit, Sharing the Load

HERE'S THE COUNTERINTUITIVE truth: giving away credit makes you look better, not worse. When you publicly celebrate a teammate's contribution, the people watching learn two things about you. First, that you're secure enough to share the spotlight. Second, that you're the kind of leader who develops people rather than using them. Both of those signal a person others want to work for and with. The manager who hoards credit looks small. The manager who distributes it looks powerful, because power that can be shared is the only kind that grows.

Early in my career, I worked with a project manager who had a gift for making everyone else's work look like his own. When executives praised the team's results, he'd nod and say thank you as if he'd done the heavy lifting personally. His rise was fast, but his fall was faster. Within two years, nobody wanted to work with him. The senior talent requested transfers. The junior talent left the company entirely. He ended up managing projects alone, drowning in work he couldn't possibly complete by himself, because he'd trained everyone around him to expect that he'd take the credit and leave them with nothing.

Among the plainest pieces of advice in Carnegie's philosophy is this: give honest, sincere appreciation, and make the other person feel important — but only if you actually mean it, because people can always tell the difference between recognition and flattery. That distinction matters more than it sounds. Flattery is telling someone what you want them to hear. Appreciation is telling them what's true. "Camille closed the Anderson account" is not flattery. It's a fact, said out loud, in front of people who have influence over her career. The project manager who took credit wasn't just being selfish — he was, in a quieter way, lying about who had actually done the work, and eventually the whole team stopped believing anything he said.

Sharing credit is mechanically simple but emotionally hard. The simple part: when someone does something good, say their name out loud in front of people who have influence over their career. “Camille closed the Anderson account.” “Priya found the bug that was crashing the build.” “Elena reorganized the shift schedule and call-outs dropped 40%.” That’s it. But the hard part is overriding the ego’s instinct to let praise land on you, especially when you did contribute, especially when you’re in a role where people already assume the good work is yours by default.

Sharing the load is the same principle applied to work itself. When you see someone drowning and you have capacity, you help. Not because it’s your job, but because you can. This could mean staying late to help a colleague format a presentation, driving a friend to the airport at 5 a.m., or simply asking “What’s on your plate this week?” and offering to take one thing off it. These moments compound. Over time, you build a reputation as someone who’s generous with their time and energy, and people respond by being generous with theirs.

The load-sharing also runs deeper. It means being willing to do the unglamorous work alongside your team instead of disappearing when the grind gets boring. When you roll up your sleeves and help with the data entry, the cleanup, the part of the project nobody wants, you send a message that you’re not above anything. That message is worth more than any motivational speech. People don’t follow people who talk about hard work. They follow people who show up and do it.

There’s a boundary here that matters. Sharing the load doesn’t mean becoming everyone’s emergency backup or doing other people’s jobs for them indefinitely. It doesn’t mean saying yes to every request until you’re the one drowning. Generosity without limits becomes resentment, and resentment poisons everything it touches. The goal is balance: be generous when you genuinely can, be honest when you can’t, and trust that a track record of real help is worth more than a track record of fake availability.

When you make sharing a habit — credit going out freely, help offered without strings — you start to notice something strange. Other people start doing it too. Your team starts saying each other’s names in meetings. Your family starts thanking each other at dinner. The culture shifts, one small act at a time. And you get to live in a place where people build each other up, instead of tearing each other

down. That's not a pipe dream. It's just the compound effect of sharing done consistently.

None of this is unique to the office. In a family, credit and load are just as unevenly shared, and just as quietly counted. The parent who plans every birthday and never hears thank you. The friend who always hosts. The sibling who calls every time. Say the name out loud: "You did the whole thing this year, and I noticed." Then do your share of the unglamorous work, the dishes, the airport pickup, the phone call to Grandma, before anyone has to ask. Resentment grows in the gap between what people do and what gets seen.

The Compound Effect of Small Human Moments

THIS IS THE part of the framework that's hardest to believe and easiest to prove: the small stuff is the big stuff. Grand gestures don't build trust. Consistent small choices do. Remembering that a friend's mother was in the hospital and asking how she's doing on Tuesday. Noticing that someone's been quiet at the table and checking in privately. Answering a message with actual warmth instead of terseness. These moments last thirty seconds each, but they accumulate into a reputation, and a set of relationships, that hold for decades.

The math is simple: if you live, work or grow up alongside the same people for years, you have thousands of interactions with them. Every one of those interactions either adds to the relationship or subtracts from it. There's no neutral. The question isn't whether you can make some big impressive move that changes everything. The question is whether you can make your average interaction slightly more human than it was last month. If you can, the compound interest will do the rest.

Derek didn't transform his team's culture in a week. He started with small things. He started saying good morning to people he used to walk past. He started asking the quiet people in meetings what they thought. He started saying "That's a good point" when someone made a good point, instead of just moving on to his own agenda. None of these things felt significant in the moment. Each one was a tiny deposit into accounts that had been empty for years. But over months, the balance shifted. People started coming to him earlier with problems. They started

defending his decisions when he wasn't in the room. They started treating each other differently too.

I think about this like a savings account. Every time you listen genuinely to someone's idea or worry, you deposit. Every time you share information that helps someone succeed, you deposit. Every time you make someone laugh at the right moment, you deposit. Every time you're short, dismissive, or tuned out, you withdraw.

Some withdrawals are inevitable — bad days happen, stress happens, humans are human. The goal isn't perfection. The goal is to keep the balance moving in the right direction over time, so that when a big withdrawal comes — a hard conversation, a disagreement, a mistake — there's enough goodwill in the account to cover it.

What makes this framework work is that it's available to everyone. You don't need a title. You don't need charisma. You don't need to be extroverted or funny or naturally warm. You just need to make a thousand small choices to be kind when you could have been indifferent, transparent when you could have been evasive, generous when you could have been stingy, and light when you could have been heavy. None of those choices is hard on its own. The hard part is making them consistently, especially on days when you'd rather not.

Marcus Aurelius wrote himself a version of the same reminder, centuries before anyone had a savings account to compare it to: stop debating what a good person looks like, and just be one, in this next interaction, starting now. He wasn't interested in becoming good in theory. He was interested in the next action. That's the whole compound-interest idea in one sentence. You don't build a reputation by resolving, in the abstract, to be a better colleague, friend or partner. You build it by making the next thirty-second interaction slightly more human than it had to be, and then doing that again tomorrow, without waiting to feel ready.

The people who do well over the long run, at work and in life, aren't the smartest or the most ambitious or the best connected. They're the ones who show up as fully human, day after day, and treat everyone else as fully human too. That's not a technique. That's a way of being. But it's a way of being that you can practice, starting right now, in your very next interaction with another person.

The framework isn't complicated. Kindness. Transparency. Humor. Sharing. Small deposits, made often. The rest is just showing up.

CHAPTER 3

The Daily Practice

SMALL HABITS AND HONEST WORDS

Starting the Day with Intent

ELENA ARRIVES AT 6:45 a.m., before the fluorescent lights of the nurse's station flicker to full brightness and before the first round of shift reports hits the printer. She pulls a sticky note from the dispenser and writes a few names: Luis, who got a tough patient assignment yesterday; Dana, who has been quiet in huddles; and Ben, who covered for her without being asked. It isn't a quota. Some mornings there are two names, some mornings there are five, and once there was only one. It takes her ninety seconds, and it changes the shape of her day.

Elena doesn't know this, but she is doing something Marcus Aurelius did nearly two thousand years ago, in tents on military campaigns, before dawn, with nobody watching and no audience to impress. He wrote to himself about the kind of person he wanted to be that day — patient with difficult people, useful to the people around him, undistracted by things outside his control — not because anyone required it of him, but because he knew that a day left unplanned would be run by whoever grabbed his attention first. His notebook was never meant to be read by anyone else; it was found and published only after his death. The three names on Elena's sticky note are the same idea, just smaller and more practical: a private commitment, made before the noise starts, about who you intend to be once it does.

The morning intent isn't about affirmations or journaling or any of that self-help theater. It's about deciding, before the chaos begins, who you're going to be in the next eight hours. When you walk in without a plan, the day makes the plan

for you. The loudest voice, the most urgent email, the most draining coworker — they grab the wheel. Writing down a few names is a small way to take it back.

It works because it's small enough to actually do. A sticky note, a note in your phone, a thought on your commute. The key is being specific about the person rather than the virtue. "Be nicer today" dissolves by 9:15. But "ask Dana how the new schedule is working for her" is something you can actually do, and more to the point, it's about Dana rather than about you.

You can adapt it to your life. If you're a manager, the names might be the people most likely to be overlooked in the week's grind. If you're a parent, one might be the child who never asks for anything. If you're neither, they might be the person at the next desk, the neighbor who has been alone since winter, and the new hire who looks lost. The job description doesn't matter. The attention does.

Something happens underneath, though it's a side effect and not the point. Luis starts returning the greeting. Dana speaks up in a huddle for the first time in weeks. Ben, who once grumbled about "the new supervisor," now asks Elena for advice. None of that was the goal, and Elena would be the first to tell you that the mornings she wrote the note hoping for exactly that were the ones where it showed. People can tell when they are being managed. What she is really doing is a private commitment, made before the noise starts, about who she intends to be once it does.

It also gives you something to come back to when the day tries to make you someone else. At 10:30, when the pharmacy calls with a problem and the schedule falls apart and a patient yells at you, you can remember: I decided this morning who I'm going to be. I'm the person who notices the steady hands. I'm the person who notices the quiet ones. The chaos can have my attention, but it can't have my identity.

Start tomorrow, and keep it humble. Before you check your email, before you open the laptop, think of the people you're about to spend the day with, at work and at home, and pick one or two you want to pay real attention to. It might be the colleague who has been quiet, or the child who has stopped telling you about school. Not "be kind to everyone." Someone specific. Then let the day happen.

Paying Attention in the Small Moments

THERE'S A BELIEF that circulates through offices, families and friendships: that connection takes time. That you need long lunches, family holidays and team retreats to build real relationships. I've found the opposite. The deepest bonds often form in tiny moments, half a minute here, a minute there, that add up to something durable. What matters is what is happening in those moments.

I've watched Elena for months now, and what strikes me is how unremarkable it looks from the outside. She's not giving speeches or winning awards. She's just stopping by Luis's station to say, "That patient transfer yesterday could have gone sideways, and you kept it steady." She's asking Dana about her daughter's soccer tryout. She's sending Ben a quick message about how his coverage saved her shift. Small, specific, and meant.

Most of us think we're already doing this. We say "How are you?" in the hallway. We send a "Hope you had a good weekend!" message. But those are pleasant-ries, and there's nothing wrong with them. A pleasantries asks a generic question and accepts a generic answer. A real moment of attention asks about something in particular and actually waits for the reply. The difference is that you were listening the first time.

Dale Carnegie, in *How to Win Friends and Influence People*, made a point that's often quoted and often misread: a person's name is, to that person, the sweetest and most important sound in any language. People remember that as a trick. Read it again and it's closer to the opposite. A name, or any detail about someone's life, is what is left over when you were actually paying attention. It only feels good to the other person because it's evidence that you cared. Learn it as a technique and it curdles. It becomes the salesman who has memorized your children's names. Let it come from real interest and it's just what caring looks like from the outside.

So the order matters. First comes attention: when someone tells you something that matters to them, you actually take it in. Remembering is what attention leaves behind. "Did your son's game get rained out Saturday?" works because you were listening when it didn't matter to anyone but them. It doesn't work because you have a good memory.

The detail doesn't have to be profound. The coworker who mentioned their dog's surgery. The teammate who was nervous about a parent-teacher conference. The new hire who said they moved from Denver. If it stuck, ask about it: "How'd the vet visit go with Biscuit?" If it didn't stick, ask honestly: "I remember you had a big week coming up. How did it go?" A sincere "remind me" is worth more than a perfectly recalled fact delivered like a slide.

The in-between moments are where this tends to happen: waiting for the coffee machine, standing at the school gate, riding in the elevator, the first minute after a meeting ends, the first minute after you walk through your own front door. These are the cracks in the day where you can either scroll your phone or look up. You don't have to make anything of them. Just notice that looking up is an option.

There's a simple test for whether you're doing this or performing it. If you'd be embarrassed for the person to see your notes, or you'd stop if you knew there would be no payoff, it's a technique and not kindness. Another version: would you still ask if nobody would ever find out you had? Face the person. Put down your phone. Give them your eyes, and mean the question. People can tell the difference between being checked on and being checked off.

And don't count on a return. Goodwill is a side effect, not a payment, and people notice when you're keeping score. Sometimes the person you paid attention to will still snap at you on Friday. Sometimes nothing visibly changes at all. What changes reliably is you: you spend your day among people rather than around them, which is a better way to spend it whether or not anyone repays you.

Don't turn this into a system. There's no list to keep and no target to hit. Start with the next person you find yourself standing next to and ask yourself, honestly, whether you're curious about how they are. If you are, ask. If you're not, ask yourself why, and then try again a little later.

How to Say Hard Things Kindly

THE HARDEST CONVERSATIONS, at work or at home, are rarely about the facts. They're about the fear underneath them. The person with something difficult to say is afraid of being resented; the person hearing it is afraid of being exposed. Put those two fears in a room and you tend to get either silence or an ex-

plosion. What changes that isn't a better script. It's walking in with a different intention — to understand rather than to win, and to leave the other person still standing when it's over.

Take feedback, the most common hard thing of all. The standard advice is the compliment sandwich: something nice, then the criticism, then something nice again. Everyone knows it's a trick, and the moment the first nice thing lands, the other person is already bracing for the "but." I'd rather be honest and curious at the same time. Say what you saw, say what it did, and then genuinely ask. "The report went out with the figures unverified, and it made for a long day for the whole team. What happened on your end?" At home it sounds much the same: "The car came back with an empty tank and I ended up late for the school pickup. What happened?" There's no formula in that. It's simply what it sounds like when you assume the other person had a reason.

That assumption is the heart of it. "Why did you?" puts people on trial; it asks for a defense. "What happened?" asks for a story, and there usually is one — too many deadlines, unclear instructions, a tool that failed, a bad night with a sick toddler. It's Hanlon's razor again, applied before you open your mouth instead of afterward. And once you know the reason, you can fix the situation instead of blaming the person.

Carnegie, as usual, got there first. Call attention to people's mistakes indirectly, he advised, and let them save face — not as a way of managing people, but because most of us fix our mistakes faster when we aren't also busy defending our dignity. Stating a failure as a fact about the person — "you missed this" — is almost always the wrong instinct. A fact about the situation, followed by an honest question, hands them their dignity back in the same breath as the problem.

Disagreement asks for the same posture. In meetings and at dinner tables it usually comes out as "That won't work" or "I don't think that's right," and both close the door. What I try to remember is that the other person is seeing something I'm not, and that I'd actually like to know what it is. So I'll say something like, "I see it differently — here's what I'm looking at. What are you seeing that I'm missing?" I'm not trying to get anything with that question. I mean it, and people can tell.

Boundaries are the hardest of the hard things, because saying no feels like breaking the relationship. But a no said kindly usually strengthens it, while a yes said resentfully poisons it, slowly and surely. What makes a no kind isn't the wording. It's that you still care what happens to the other person after you've said it. "I can't take on the vendor calls this week — I'm full with the budget deadline — but I'll write down how they work so whoever picks them up isn't lost." Or, with family: "I can't host the holidays this year; I'm running on empty. But I'd love to do the desserts." You're saying no to the task, not to the person.

Underneath all of this is tone, which carries at least half the weight. The perfect words said in a clipped, hurried voice still leave a bruise. I've learned to slow down before the hard thing leaves my mouth — one breath, a slightly lower voice — not as a trick, but because the slower version of me is the one who actually cares how it lands. It's the difference between a door slamming and a door being held open.

And then, mostly, listen. If you rehearse the whole conversation in advance, you'll be reciting lines while the other person is talking, and you'll miss everything they say. Know what you want to say in one plain sentence, know what you'd like to understand, and let the rest unfold. The hard thing felt hard because you were afraid of the reaction. When you really listen, that reaction usually turns out to be smaller, and far more human, than the one you imagined.

I've seen this in some tense rooms and some tense kitchens. The nervous team lead who said, "The deployment failed twice and the client call slipped to Friday. What happened in testing?" The burned-out coordinator who said, "I can't keep covering evenings, but I've sketched a schedule that spreads them out fairly." The daughter who told her father, "I can't talk about the will every Sunday, but I'd love to plan the summer trip with you." None of them had a formula. They had simply decided, before they spoke, that the other person mattered more than being right, and the words followed. It didn't make those conversations easy. It made them possible, and possible is enough to start with.

Reading the Room — and the Person

MOST OF US enter rooms the way we enter elevators: eyes forward, head down, focused on getting through it. And so we miss what's actually going on — not the topic on the table, but the human weather. Who's tense? Who's gone quiet?

Who's been talked over three times and has stopped trying? Reading the room isn't a mystical skill. It's just attention, pointed at other people instead of at yourself.

Sun Tzu opened *The Art of War* by insisting that no campaign should begin without first understanding the ground you're standing on — the terrain, the weather, the state of your own side and the other. He was writing about armies, but the principle transfers almost without translation. A meeting, a wedding, a family lunch is terrain. The agenda, or the plan for the day, is the map, but the map is never the territory. Someone drew that map assuming a calm room, and the room might not be calm. The person who walks in only reading the agenda is working with half the available information. The one who notices the weather first has already found the higher ground.

Most of what there is to notice is plain to see. Shoulders up near the ears. Arms folded tight. The coffee nobody has touched, the pen clicking faster and faster. We take in all of it without meaning to, and then ignore it because we're busy with our own agenda. The shift is simply to stop ignoring it — to walk into a meeting, or a family dinner, and let yourself wonder for a moment who's uncomfortable, and why.

The gaps tell you even more. The person who always speaks up is silent; the one who always jokes isn't joking. A group keeps circling a problem without ever landing on it. Every room has a texture, and the texture changes when something is wrong. You don't need a method to notice that. You only need to care enough to look.

The same is true of one person over time. Some people get louder when they're stressed and some go very quiet; some ask more questions and some stop asking altogether. When you've paid attention to someone for a while, you start to recognize their weather before the storm — before the snap, before the withdrawal, before the email they'll regret sending.

There's a line here worth being careful about. Paying attention isn't surveillance, and it isn't a way of gaining an edge. If you're reading a room in order to steer it, people will feel steered. The point is to know when to pause, when to ask, when to offer help and when to leave a moment alone. It's attention in the service of kindness, not in the service of control.

Before a conversation that matters — a hard meeting, a phone call with your mother, a check-in with someone who seems off — I try to set my own agenda down for a moment and simply wonder how the other person is doing. What is their body saying? What haven't they said yet? What's the temperature of the room, or the thread? It isn't a checklist. It's more like looking up before you cross the road, and more often than not it changes what I say next.

Sometimes you'll read it wrong, and that's fine; nobody is a mind reader. If you guess someone is upset and ask, and they say they're fine, you take the answer and leave it there. The aim was never to extract a confession. It was to notice, and then to be gentle enough to respect what you're told. Even that small moment of noticing tends to change how you treat them for the rest of the day.

This kind of attention never makes it onto a résumé, but it's what separates the managers people confide in from the ones they avoid, and the friends and parents people call from the ones they only text. It isn't charisma. It's caring, practiced long enough that it has become the way you look at people.

When to Use Humor — and When to Hold Back

HUMOR IS ONE of the warmest things we have, and one of the sharpest. Used well, it eases tension, makes you approachable, and turns a group of people into a team, or a family. Used badly, it makes people feel mocked, dismissed or small. The difference isn't talent. It's what's in your heart when you reach for the joke.

A few quiet questions tend to sit underneath good humor, and people who are good at it rarely have to ask them out loud. The first is whether anyone is paying for the laugh. Self-deprecation is fine — that's you offering your own foibles to the room — but a joke that lands on a particular person, on someone's identity or on someone's work is a debt with interest. It feels fine in the moment and comes due later.

The second is whether it fits the weather. If the room is grieving, absorbing bad news or wrestling with something serious, the comedic instinct has to stand down. Humor doesn't always lighten a mood; sometimes the mood needs to stay heavy so people can get through it. The right joke at the wrong time sounds like a dismissal of everyone's pain.

The third is the sneaky one: am I reaching for this to connect, or to protect myself? A lot of humor is really avoidance — we crack a joke because we're uncomfortable, or because sincerity feels too exposed. If you notice yourself reaching for a quip just as the conversation gets real, it may be your own discomfort talking. Let the sincerity have its moment.

Dudeism — half joke, half genuine philosophy, built loosely on much older ideas about flowing with life instead of gripping it — would call all of this overthinking, and it would be half right. The relaxed, unbothered approach to a room is real and it works, but it works because the person using it has already done the noticing. They're not oblivious to the weather; they've just made peace with not controlling it. That's the actual wisdom hiding inside "taking it easy." It isn't indifference. It's having decided, ahead of time, that you don't need to win every room, which frees you to notice what the room needs instead of what would make you look good in it.

When humor comes from the right place, it tends to live in the middle lane: warm, observational, a little self-aware. Not the fast lane of edgy material that belongs in a comedy club, and not the hard shoulder of constant puns that make everyone wince. The absurd font on the quarterly report. The printer that jams the minute before a deadline. The shared humanity of forgetting which meeting you're in, or which cousin is married to whom.

The best of it is the humor of recognition — naming a common experience so precisely that everyone laughs in relief. "Has anyone else had three different answers from IT about the VPN, or is that just me?" Nobody is the target and everybody is included. Humor about the situation, rather than about the people in it, is almost always safe ground.

Timing matters too. A joke at the very start of a meeting, while people are still settling, can feel like a performance; the same joke twenty minutes in, after a tense back-and-forth, feels like relief. Let the room tell you when it needs one.

And if you're not naturally funny, don't force it. Honest warmth beats strained wit every time. The point of humor between people was never to be the funniest one there; it's to be someone whose lightness makes others feel safe. When in doubt, choose warmth over wit. People remember how you made them feel, not how clever your punchline was.

CHAPTER 4

When It Goes Wrong

REPAIR, RECOVERY, AND RESILIENCE

The Apology That Actually Works

TOMÁS SAT IN his car in the parking garage for eleven minutes after the budget meeting. He kept replaying the moment he snapped at Lena, the charge nurse, in front of three other people. The look on her face was still sharp in his mind. He had apologized to people before, of course. But this felt different. This felt like the kind of mistake that leaves a mark. Most of us have been in that parking garage in some form. We said the sharp thing, sent the curt email, dismissed the idea too quickly. And then we sat there wondering: what do I do now?

Here's what most people do. They either pretend it didn't happen and hope everyone forgets, or they apologize in a way that makes everything worse. They say things like "I'm sorry if you were offended" or "I was just stressed" or "I didn't mean it that way." These aren't apologies. These are defenses wearing apology clothing. The other person hears the qualifier, not the remorse. They hear the subtext: this is your fault for feeling hurt. And the distance between you grows a little wider.

Epictetus, who was born a slave and became one of the great teachers of Stoicism, built almost his entire philosophy on a single distinction — the one Marcus Aurelius later absorbed from a copy of his lectures and spent a lifetime trying to live by. Some things are up to us, Epictetus taught, and some things are not. Our own judgments, choices and actions are ours; nearly everything else — other people, our reputation, what has already happened — isn't. Tomás couldn't control how loudly the budget meeting had gone, how tired he'd been, or how

Lena's face looked when he snapped. All of that had already happened. What remained entirely his — the only part of the situation still in his hands — was what he said and did next. An apology that starts from there doesn't waste energy relitigating the meeting or explaining the stress. It goes straight to the one thing that's still his.

A real apology doesn't need to be long or theatrical, and it isn't a formula. It's simply what honesty sounds like when you've hurt someone. You name what you actually did — not "I'm sorry about the meeting," but "I'm sorry I raised my voice and criticized your staffing plan in front of the team" — because vagueness tells the other person you haven't really looked at it. You acknowledge what it did to them without arguing: "I know that embarrassed you." You don't get to decide whether someone else was hurt; you only get to decide whether you care that they were. You say what will be different, because words mean little without a changed pattern. And then you stop. No "but." No tour of your stress, your workload or your bad night's sleep. Everything after a "but" is about you, and the apology was supposed to be about them.

Tomás tried this approach with Lena. He found her in the break room at the end of the day, asked if he could have two minutes, and delivered the apology without embellishment. He didn't tell her about the budget pressure or the email from corporate or the argument with his brother that morning. He just told her what he did, acknowledged that it hurt, and told her what he would change. Lena said nothing for a few seconds. Then she said, "Thank you. That actually means something." And that was it. The relationship didn't instantly become perfect, but it didn't degrade either. The crack was sealed before it could become a fault line.

It's no different outside the office. A friend of mine once missed his daughter's recital because a work call ran long. He didn't say "I was swamped." He said, "I missed your recital. I know how long you practiced, I know it hurt, and from now on it goes in my calendar first." She was nine. She said, "Okay, Dad," and climbed into his lap. Nothing else he could have said would have worked as well.

The hard part about apologizing well is that it requires swallowing your pride at the exact moment your pride is screaming loudest. Your brain will offer you a dozen reasons why the other person overreacted, why you were right, why you

shouldn't have to grovel. None of those reasons matter if your goal is to keep the relationship intact. Apology isn't about winning the argument. It's about winning the person. And the person is almost always worth more than the point. The moment you add justification, the apology collapses under its own weight. The other person doesn't need your explanation. They need your accountability.

One more thing: timing matters. An apology delivered too quickly can feel rushed and insincere. An apology delivered too late can feel like an afterthought. The sweet spot is usually within twenty-four hours, once both of you have had time to cool down but before the incident hardens into permanent resentment. If you wait a week, the other person has already told the story to three friends and quietly decided what it says about you. Don't make them wait that long. Showing up to repair quickly is its own form of respect.

Handling the Person Who Won't Engage

SOME PEOPLE DON'T want to connect. They answer questions with one word. They keep their headphones on. They do their work, log off, and vanish. And if you've tried kindness, transparency, and humor with them and gotten nothing back, it's easy to feel rejected. It's easy to take it personally. But that's the trap. Their distance is almost never about you. It's about exhaustion, past betrayals, mental health, family stress, or simply a personality that doesn't crave social connection the way yours does.

This is where Epictetus earns his place again. Whether a withdrawn coworker, relative or neighbor chooses to open up to you is simply not up to you, however kind you are. What is up to you is whether you keep showing up as a decent, steady presence regardless of what they give back. Pinning your peace on their response will always leave you disappointed, because their response was never yours to begin with. Pinning it on your own steadiness never will, because that's the only part that was ever really yours.

What that looks like, mostly, is patience. Lower your expectations without lowering your standards. You don't need this person to become your friend. You need to coexist productively and respectfully. If they answer in one word, accept the one word. If they don't laugh at your joke, let the joke go. The goal isn't to win them over. The goal is to be consistently decent, consistently clear, and con-

sistently unbothered by their distance. That consistency builds a quiet form of trust, even if they never acknowledge it.

It also helps to meet them where they already are. Some people will never open up over coffee, but they'll respond to a direct question about something they care about: a work problem, the garden, the car, the game. Instead of asking "How was your weekend?" ask "What do you think about the new scheduling software?" or "How do you get your tomatoes to do that?" Rather than forcing a chat, find something you can do or care about together. Shared work, or a shared interest, is the one thing you reliably have with this person. It's the bridge that doesn't require either of you to pretend to be something you're not.

And respect the boundary they've drawn. If someone clearly doesn't want to talk about their personal life, don't keep probing. If they don't want to join the team lunch or the family barbecue, don't pressure them. Every time you respect a boundary without sulking about it, you send a message that their comfort matters to you. That message lands even when it doesn't get a verbal response. Over time, it can soften the hardest shell.

Most of the time, though, the person who won't engage isn't trying to hurt you. This is Hanlon's razor from Chapter 1 doing its quiet work again: never attribute to malice what carelessness, exhaustion or fear can explain. They're just trying to survive. They're wearing armor you can't see. Your job isn't to tear the armor off. Your job is to show them, through a thousand small consistent choices, that you're not the threat they might have assumed. Some of them will never warm up. But some of them will, very slowly, begin to trust. And the few who do will remember that you were patient when you had every right not to be.

There's also a version of this where the person does engage, but only in ways that are hostile or undermining. They snipe at you in meetings, or at family gatherings. They point out your mistakes publicly. They're not distant; they're actively unpleasant. That's a different problem and it requires a different response. The principle is the same: don't mirror their hostility. Keep your responses calm, specific and focused on the matter at hand. Say "I'd prefer we discuss that directly rather than in front of the group." Say "I hear your concern. Let's set up time to walk through it." You can't control their behavior, but you can refuse to be drawn into a fight. Taking it personally and withdrawing is the worst possible response,

because it confirms whatever story they have told themselves about people. And you can document the pattern if it crosses into harassment or bullying.

Recovering from a Bad Day — or a Bad Season

BAD DAYS HAPPEN. You snap at a coworker, or at your kids, because you're tired. You dismiss an idea because you're behind on a deadline and your brain is full. You sit through a meeting with your arms crossed and your jaw tight and everyone notices. Maybe you didn't even say anything, but the energy coming off you was enough to make the room feel colder. And then you go home and lie awake wondering if you have undone months of goodwill in a single afternoon. The fear is real. But the fear is usually wrong.

A bad season is harder, because it's not one incident but a slow accumulation. Maybe you've been distracted for weeks by a family crisis and the people around you have been carrying more than their share. Maybe you made a decision that went wrong and the team is still cleaning up the mess. Maybe you just feel like you've been a worse version of yourself for a while and you're not sure anyone has noticed but you're sure they have. The instinct is to overcorrect, to start being extra nice, extra funny, extra present in a way that feels forced. Don't do that. People can smell forced cheerfulness from across the building. What they need isn't a performance. They need acknowledgment.

Viktor Frankl, studying what actually gets people through genuinely hard stretches of life, landed on a conclusion that sounds almost too optimistic until you sit with it: the stretch itself doesn't determine how it will shape you. What determines that is the meaning you're able to find within it, and the attitude you choose to bring to it while it's happening. A rough season isn't a verdict on your character. It's raw material. You get to decide, at least partly, whether it becomes a story about a season where you let people down, or a story about a season where you were honest about struggling and showed up anyway. Both are available. Only one of them is worth choosing.

There's a specific kind of shame that attaches to being the one who let people down. It makes you want to hide. It makes you want to work later, say less, make up for it in silence. But silence is the worst tool for rebuilding. The silence gives other people room to invent stories about what's going on with you, and the stor-

ies they invent are usually worse than the truth. “She doesn’t care anymore.” “He’s checked out and looking for another job.” “They don’t respect the work we’re doing.” The only way to counter those invented stories is with the real one.

So be transparent about what’s happening and what you’re doing about it. It feels vulnerable. It’s vulnerable. And vulnerability, when it’s offered without drama, is one of the fastest ways to rebuild a connection that has started to fray. Have a quick word or send an honest message. Say something like: “I know I haven’t been at my best lately. I want to acknowledge that and tell you what I’m doing about it.” Then tell them. If you need to step back from a project, tell them. If you need help, tell them. If you just need a week to reset and then you’ll be back at full capacity, tell them. The content of the message matters less than the fact that you sent it. You’re telling the people around you: I see the impact I’ve been having, and I’m not pretending otherwise. That’s the difference between a person having a hard season and a person becoming someone no one trusts.

People are more forgiving than we give them credit for. They know what a bad day feels like. They’ve had their own moments of snapping and sulking and being the person who makes the room colder. What they remember isn’t the bad day itself. What they remember is what you did afterward. If you show up the next morning and act like nothing happened, they’ll assume you don’t care. If you show up and say “I was off yesterday, and I’m sorry if that came through,” they’ll almost always shrug and tell you not to worry about it. The reset is that simple. And the honesty of admitting you were off actually builds more trust than if you had never been off at all.

And if the bad season becomes a bad year? If the team, or the family, has turned toxic and you’ve been part of the problem? That’s a bigger conversation. But the starting point is the same. You name what’s true. You take responsibility for your piece. You ask what would help. You follow through. The details change depending on the situation. The principle doesn’t. Repair always starts with honesty.

When Humor Falls Flat

YOU MADE A joke and no one laughed. Worse, someone looked uncomfortable. Maybe someone asked you quietly afterward if you really meant it. Maybe

someone sent you a message that said “Hey, just so you know, that comment didn’t land well.” The feeling is like swallowing ice water. You were trying to be the person who lightens the room, and instead you became the person who made the room go quiet. It happens to everyone who uses humor. It will happen to you again. The only question is what you do next.

The worst response is to defend the joke. “It was just a joke.” “People are too sensitive these days.” “Everyone else thought it was funny.” Every one of these responses digs the hole deeper. They tell the person who was hurt that their feelings are an inconvenience you would rather not deal with. They also tell everyone who witnessed the miss that you’re more interested in being right than in being kind. The joke was the problem. The defensiveness is what makes people stop trusting you.

If the joke didn’t hurt anyone but just fell flat, the recovery is easier. A quick self-deprecating acknowledgment works: “Well, that one didn’t land. Moving on.”

The moment you acknowledge the silence, you release the tension in the room. The silence was about your joke dying. Now it’s about you being human enough to notice. People respect that. They have all been there. The ability to laugh at yourself is actually one of the strongest social signals you can send. It says: I’m not fragile, I’m not defensive, and I don’t take myself so seriously that I can’t survive a bad joke.

This is, not coincidentally, how the Dude treats a gutter ball. A failed joke isn’t a referendum on your worth as a person. It’s one frame in a very long game. The unbothered move isn’t to pretend it didn’t happen and it’s not to defend it — both of those grip the moment too tightly. The unbothered move is to notice it, let it go, and roll the next frame. That’s not indifference to the miss. It’s just refusing to let one miss become the whole match.

When the joke did hurt someone, the right response is different: fast, specific, and private. If you know the joke landed badly, don’t wait for someone else to bring it up. Go to the person who was affected and say: “That joke I made in the meeting was out of line. I’m sorry. It won’t happen again.” No caveats. No explanation of what you meant. No request for them to lighten up. Just a clean acknowledgment that you crossed a line and you’re owning it. And then, actually,

don't make that joke again. Not a version of it. Not a softer version of it. Drop it. The lesson from a failed joke isn't "find a better way to say the same thing." The lesson is that the thing you thought was funny wasn't funny to the person you said it to, and their reaction matters more than your intention.

The harder part is deciding whether to use humor at all after a miss. Some people overcorrect and go completely humorless, which makes them stiff and unapproachable. Others keep swinging and miss again and again, which makes them seem oblivious. The middle path is to learn from each miss. Pay attention to what kind of humor landed badly. Was it sarcasm? Was it teasing? Was it a reference to something sensitive? Was it directed at a person rather than a situation? Once you know your own bad habits, you can steer around them. Good humor is warm, inclusive, and aimed at the situation, not the person. It makes people laugh without making anyone the butt of the joke. If you can't make the joke without making someone the target, don't make the joke.

And when you do get it right, notice how it feels. The right joke at the right moment can turn a tense meeting into a productive one. It can break the ice with a new hire. It can make you someone people want on their team, at their table, in their life. Humor is worth keeping, and worth growing into. Every miss is information. Every recovery is practice. Over time, you develop an instinct for the difference between a joke that heals and a joke that hurts, and you choose accordingly without even thinking about it.

Protecting Your Own Energy

THERE'S A VERSION of being good with people that comes at a high cost. You become the one everyone comes to with their problems. You become the peacemaker, the listener, the one who absorbs tension and soothes it. You give and give until you're empty, and then you keep giving from the reserves because that's what you have always done. This isn't sustainable. It's not virtuous. It's self-sacrifice disguised as kindness, and it will eventually make you resent the people you're trying to help.

The first sign of energy depletion is often physical. You're exhausted at the end of the day even though you didn't do anything physically demanding. Your shoulders ache. Your attention scatters. You start avoiding people not because

they're difficult but because even the easy ones feel like work. You snap at someone innocent and the snap surprises you as much as it surprises them. These aren't signs that you're failing at being kind. They're signs that you've been running on empty and the tank just hit the warning light.

Protecting your energy isn't about becoming cold or unavailable. It's about being intentional with your capacity. It starts with accepting that you can't be everything to everyone. Some people will be disappointed when you don't answer the 9 p.m. message. Some people will be annoyed when you say no to the favor they asked for. That disappointment doesn't make you a bad person. It makes you a person with limits, and people with limits are more trustworthy than people without them, because you know exactly where the boundary is and you can rely on what's inside it.

Even Marcus Aurelius, a man who genuinely believed his highest duty was service to others, kept reminding himself of a boundary most people miss: that his obligation was to act rightly, not to absorb the full weight of everyone else's mood, expectations, and demands as though they were his own to carry. Those are two different jobs. The first is sustainable indefinitely. The second isn't sustainable for anyone, and pretending otherwise isn't virtue — it's just a slower way of becoming unable to help anyone at all.

There's a companion idea worth borrowing here from Frankl. He argued that what actually sustains a person through a demanding stretch isn't grinding harder — it's having a clear enough sense of why the effort matters that the effort itself stops feeling purely depleting. The people-pleaser who says yes to everything out of fear of disappointing someone is running on a different fuel than the person who says yes selectively because they've decided, on their own terms, what their presence is actually for. The first runs out. The second, even when tired, tends to find the reserve tank, because the giving is anchored to something they chose rather than something they're afraid of losing.

It also helps to build small pockets of rest into your day. These don't have to be elaborate. Ten minutes alone with coffee before the first meeting. A walk outside at lunch without your phone. Five minutes in the car before you drive home, or before you walk through the front door, just breathing. These aren't selfish indulgences. They're maintenance. You wouldn't expect a piece of equipment to run

forever without downtime. You shouldn't expect that of yourself either. The amazing thing is how much more genuinely kind you can be when you've had ten minutes to yourself. You're not performing patience anymore. You actually have some.

And it means recognizing when kindness becomes enabling. If you're constantly covering for a teammate, or a grown child, who doesn't do their part, that's not kindness. That's collusion with dysfunction. If you're absorbing someone's emotional outbursts without ever asking them to take responsibility for managing their own reactions, you're not helping them. You're teaching them that you'll always be their cushion. Real kindness sometimes looks like saying no. It sometimes looks like letting someone feel the consequences of their actions. It sometimes looks like stepping back so someone else can step up. The kindest thing you can do for a person is to believe they're capable of more, even when that belief means not rescuing them.

Finally, it helps to know the difference between tired and depleted. Tired is fixed by a good night of sleep and a day off. Depleted is fixed by reevaluating your commitments, setting boundaries, and sometimes walking away from situations that are draining you beyond what you can sustain. The world will take as much as you're willing to give. Your coworkers, your family and your friends will take as much as you're willing to offer, and most of them won't even notice. No one will hand you a permission slip to rest. You have to write it yourself. And when you do, you'll find that the quality of your presence improves so much that people stop missing the burned-out version of you entirely.

CHAPTER 5

Becoming the Person People Want Around

WHO YOU BECOME ALONG THE WAY

From Doing to Being

AISHA WATCHED THE panel from the back of the auditorium, her coffee going cold in her hands. The woman at the center of the stage was leading a discussion about equity in higher education with a confidence Aisha remembered from somewhere else entirely. Seven years ago, this same woman had sat in her office, twenty-two years old, furious about a grade on a research paper. Aisha remembered the impulse to defend the grade, to list the rubric criteria, to win. Instead, she had asked one question: What feels unfair about this? The fury had cracked open into something real. That moment didn't feel like a technique. It felt like a choice about who she wanted to be.

There's a version of this book that teaches you moves. Say this. Do that. Smile here. But if you've made it this far, you already know the moves aren't the point. The point is what happens when the moves stop feeling like moves. When you stop checking the mental list of kind things to do and simply become the kind of person who does them. That's the shift no chapter can script for you. It happens quietly, over time, and one day someone tells a story about you and you realize the story isn't about what you did. It's about who you are.

The difference between doing and being sounds abstract, but it shows up in concrete ways. The person who is doing kindness says thank you because it's on the checklist and then checks the box and moves on. The person who is being kind actually feels the gratitude pass through them for half a second before the words leave their mouth. The person who is doing transparency shares informa-

tion because they read that it builds trust. The person who is being transparent shares because withholding no longer occurs to them. Same action. Different frequency. People can tell the difference the way you can tell a real smile from a polite one.

Marcus Aurelius returns to this exact distinction again and again in *Meditations*, in different words each time, because he seems to have struggled with it his whole life. His version was blunt: stop merely discussing what a good person is like, and instead actually be one. He wasn't writing a philosophy textbook for other people to admire. He was arguing with himself, in the middle of the night, about the gap between the person he described in theory and the person he actually was in the next conversation. That gap is exactly what Aisha noticed closing in herself over seven years. It doesn't close by reading more about kindness. It closes by choosing it, badly at first, in real rooms, with real stakes, often enough that eventually there's no gap left to notice.

This shift doesn't require a personality transplant. You don't have to become gregarious if you're quiet, or jokey if you're serious. The framework from earlier in this book works precisely because it can take the shape of whoever you already are. Kindness from an introvert looks like a well-timed check-in. Transparency from a private person looks like saying what you can share now rather than hiding behind a non-answer. Humor from a measured person looks like a dry observation at exactly the right moment. The goal isn't to be more like someone else. The goal is to remove whatever is keeping you from acting like yourself at your best.

There's a moment in the process that feels like a phase change. Ice becoming water. You can't pinpoint the hour it happened, but you know it did. For Aisha, it was the day she realized she had stopped rehearsing hard conversations before walking into them. The careful rehearsing had been a lifeline at first. Then it became scaffolding. Then one morning she sat down across from someone difficult and simply said what needed to be said, kindly and clearly, without once reaching for a mental index card. That's where all of this is heading. Not perfect. Not effortless. But natural in a way that only comes from repetition with intention.

You'll know you're becoming rather than doing when your internal monologue changes. The person who is doing asks, What should I say to handle this person? The person who is being asks, What does this person actually need right

now, and can I help? The second question isn't noble by accident. It's efficient. It cuts through the noise of self-presentation and goes straight to the actual situation. When you stop managing impressions and start responding to reality, everything gets quieter. You have fewer tabs open in your head. The work of communicating becomes lighter because you're no longer carrying the weight of performance.

So how do you make the shift from doing to being? Not by forcing it. You make it the way you get better at anything that matters: small choices, repeated, observed. Notice when the kind thing felt natural and when it felt strained. Notice when you shared something and it felt good, and when you shared too much and it felt hollow. Notice the physical difference between humor that connected and humor that deflected. Earlier chapters described habits. This one is about the point where the habits stop feeling like habits and start feeling like you.

The truth is, you're already becoming. The fact that you picked up this book and have read this far means the shift has started. Interest is the first crack in the old pattern. You can't unsee what you now see about how people respond to genuine connection. The only question is whether you'll keep choosing it until it chooses you back. It will. Not all at once, and not in every room. But the person you're becoming is already someone other people want to be around. You just have to catch up to yourself.

The shift also changes how you experience your own mistakes. The person doing kindness tends to spiral when they snap at someone, because the snap feels like failure of the whole project. The person being kind recognizes the snap as a moment in a long relationship. They address it, repair it as this book has described, and keep going. Identity is what allows you to fail without becoming a failure. You can have a bad day without being a bad person. That's not a loophole. That's the foundation that makes the whole practice sustainable.

The Long Game of Reputation

NO ONE WAKES up on a Tuesday and decides to build a reputation. Reputation is what happens while you're busy making thousands of small choices that nobody notices at the time. The colleague who remembers that you listened when they were struggling. The former direct report who tells a new hire that you were

the first manager who actually shared credit. The peer who watched you handle a nasty email with grace and thought, I want to handle it like that. The friend who remembers you sat with her in a hospital waiting room. The neighbor who knows you always brought the bins in without being asked. None of those moments felt historic when they happened. All of them are now part of your permanent record in the only court that matters: other people's memories.

A former colleague of Aisha's, a man named Edwin who worked in facilities for two decades, illustrated this better than any leadership book ever could. Edwin wasn't on any org chart that mattered. He wasn't in the room for the big decisions. But he had spent twenty years being exactly the person he appeared to be. He told the truth about what was broken. He laughed in a way that made other people laugh. He thanked people by name. When a new dean took over and asked the staff who the institution should listen to, Edwin's name came up again and again. Not because he had angled for it. Because he had built it, one hallway conversation at a time.

Sun Tzu would have recognized exactly what Edwin was doing, even though Edwin had probably never read a word of *The Art of War*. Sun Tzu argued that the campaigns won most decisively are the ones where the outcome was secured long before anyone showed up to fight — through positioning, patience, and quiet preparation, not through a single dramatic confrontation. Edwin never had a dramatic confrontation. He never needed one. By the time the new dean asked who mattered, the campaign, if you want to call it that, was already twenty years won. Nobody could out-argue that kind of reputation in a single meeting, because it wasn't built in meetings. It was built in hallways, over decades, one small deposit at a time, exactly the way this book has been describing all along.

The long game isn't glamorous, which is why so few people play it. The short game offers immediate rewards: taking credit feels good right now. Withholding information preserves your edge today. Dodging a difficult conversation buys you a peaceful afternoon. The long game offers something else entirely: a compounding return on the trust you deposit one small transaction at a time. The math isn't linear. For years, the balance looks modest. Then one day someone advocates for you in a room you're not in, and you never even know it happened.

The opposite is also true, and it's worth naming honestly. Reputation built on self-promotion has a different texture. People can sense when your kindness is a coat you put on for certain rooms and take off in others. They may not call you out. They may not even fully articulate what feels off. But the feeling is there, and it shapes what they say when you're not around. The long game asks you to be the same person in the boardroom and at the kitchen table, not because you're performing consistency, but because you're actually consistent.

One of the quiet gifts of the long game is that it reduces your dependence on any single moment going well. If your reputation rests on one big presentation or one high-stakes negotiation, the pressure is enormous. If it rests on hundreds of small interactions that all point the same direction, any one of them can go sideways without sinking you. You get the freedom to take risks, to make mistakes, to be human, because the ledger is already healthy. People who have watched you be genuine for years will give you the benefit of the doubt that strangers never would.

There's also a practical discipline to playing the long game: keep your promises, especially the small ones. If you say you'll send the file by Friday, send it by Friday. If you tell your daughter you'll be at the game, be at the game. If you promise to advocate for someone in a meeting, speak up in the meeting. If you tell a coworker you'll think about their idea and get back to them, actually think about it and actually get back to them. These aren't glamorous commitments. They're load-bearing. Every small promise kept is a brick in the structure. Every small promise broken is a crack. The cracks don't collapse the building on their own, but they matter when the storm comes.

It helps to zoom out once in a while and look at your own life from the perspective of ten years from now. What would you want the people around you now, colleagues, friends, family, to say about you at that future point, when the projects and the arguments and the busy seasons are long past? That you were smart? There are smart people everywhere. That you were right? Being right fades fast. More likely you would want them to say that you made the work better and the people around you feel seen. That you were the kind of person they would happily spend time with again, given the chance. That kind of reputation is rarer than talent and more durable than charisma. It's worth building, and it's built ex-

actly the way you would build anything of lasting value: slowly, steadily, and on purpose.

The long game has no finish line, which is part of its power. You're never done building the person people remember. Every week offers new deposits and new withdrawals. The goal isn't a perfect record. It's a clear trajectory. When you look back over the span of years, the trend should be unmistakable: more trust, not less. More people who know what you stand for, not fewer. More moments when you were the person someone needed at exactly the right time, even if you never knew it. That's the legacy ledger, and it compounds.

Mentoring and Paying It Forward

MENTORING IS OFTEN framed as a formal relationship: the senior leader who takes a promising junior under their wing, the scheduled coffee meetings, the career advice. That version exists and has value. But the mentoring that actually shapes careers is usually informal and unannounced. It's the passing comment in the hallway. The quick story you tell about how you handled a similar situation. The time you admit you made the same mistake and survived it. It's the way a grandfather shows a boy how to hold a hammer, and the way an older sister goes first so the younger one knows it's safe. You're mentoring people all the time without knowing it. The question is what kind of mentoring you're doing.

The woman on the panel was named Imani. After the auditorium emptied, Aisha stayed to help stack chairs, a habit from her early days as an adjunct that she had never dropped. Imani walked over, still holding her notes, and said something that stopped Aisha's hands mid-chair. You once told me I didn't have to be nice to be taken seriously, but that being kind would make being taken seriously easier. I think about that all the time. Aisha didn't remember saying it. That was the point. You don't get to know which moments will stick in another person's mind for seven years. You just offer them and let them go.

Frankl believed something worth sitting with here: that people find the deepest, most durable meaning not by chasing their own fulfillment directly, but by giving themselves to something or someone beyond themselves — a piece of work, a cause, another person's growth. Aisha wasn't trying to build a legacy seven years earlier, when she answered a furious twenty-two-year-old's question honestly in-

stead of defending a grade. She was just doing the next small, decent thing in front of her. The meaning showed up seven years later, uninvited, in an auditorium, carried by a sentence she didn't even remember saying. That's usually how it works. The meaning is rarely visible from inside the moment. It only shows up later, when someone tells you what it turned out to be.

Paying it forward isn't charity. It's maintenance. The world you want to live in doesn't build itself. It's the cumulative product of thousands of small choices about how people treat each other. When you mentor someone, you're not just helping them navigate their career. You're shaping what they'll consider normal and acceptable when they eventually have influence over others. That new hire who watched you share credit will share credit when they lead a project. The colleague who saw you handle criticism with equanimity will be more likely to do the same. The niece who watched you apologize to her mother will know that apologizing is what grown-ups do. The culture compounds, for better or worse.

It matters, too, why you're doing it. There's a version of paying it forward that's really just networking wearing a nicer outfit — help this person now because they might be useful later, keep a mental ledger, expect the favor to circle back eventually. That version is exhausting to sustain, and most people can smell it anyway. The version that actually works is simpler and has nothing to do with a plan: you help people because you want to, because you genuinely want the people around you to be happy and to succeed, full stop, no invoice attached. Jesus put a version of this plainly to his own followers — freely you have received, freely give — and it circles back to something from earlier in this book: if you happened to get the right book, hear the right idea, or receive the right piece of advice at a moment when you needed it, you didn't earn that timing. Someone gave it to you, or you stumbled into it. The only honest response is to pass it along the same way it came to you — freely, without keeping score.

There's a natural resistance that comes up here, and it's worth being honest about it. Mentoring takes time. You're busy. Your plate is full. The junior colleague's questions sometimes feel like they arrive at exactly the wrong moment. The resistance is real, but it's also short-sighted. Every minute you spend helping someone else get better at the thing you already know how to do is a minute invested in the people around you, the team, and the network that will carry you

through your own future unknowns. The math isn't obvious day to day, but over time it's undeniable.

The principles in this book transfer through modeling far more than through instruction. You can explain kindness until you're hoarse, but the moment that will land with a junior colleague is the moment they watch you be kind to someone who can't advance your career. You can talk about transparency in abstract terms, but the lesson that will stick is the time they saw you share difficult news honestly and then sit in the discomfort without running from it. People learn how to be with others by watching the people around them, especially those a step or two ahead. You're on stage more often than you realize.

Aisha kept a simple practice that made mentoring feel less like an obligation and more like a reflex. She asked herself, each week, one question: Who did I help get smarter this week? Not who did I help complete a task, but who did I help understand something they didn't understand before? If the answer was nobody, she didn't spiral about it. She just noticed. And the noticing, over time, changed her default settings. She started looking for the teaching moment in ordinary work instead of waiting for a formal invitation to mentor. The shift in framing made all the difference. Mentoring stopped being a program and became a posture.

One of the unexpected rewards of paying it forward is that it keeps your own skills sharp. Explaining something to someone newer than you forces you to see it fresh, to strip away the accumulated shorthand and get back to first principles. You can't teach the daily practices from earlier in this book without remembering why they matter, and remembering why they matter reconnects you to your own practice. Mentoring is a two-way street not because the mentee has equal wisdom to offer, but because the act of teaching is itself a form of learning. You get better at what you explain.

The legacy question from earlier in this chapter comes back here in its most practical form. What will you leave behind? Not in the abstract sense of organizational change or industry impact, but in the specific sense of other people. The colleagues who learned something from watching you. The children and nieces and neighbors' kids who carry your ways of treating people into their own homes. The strangers who will never know your name but will benefit from the culture

you helped reinforce. That's the only permanence available to any of us, and it's more than enough.

Staying Human Under Pressure

DEADLINES DON'T CARE about your personal growth. Layoffs don't pause while you practice your new communication habits. The test of everything in this book isn't how you behave on a calm Tuesday with a full night of sleep behind you. The test is how you behave at 4:45 p.m. on a Friday when the project is on fire, leadership is asking questions you can't answer, and the colleague who always underdelivers has just forwarded you the timeline for a task you thought was theirs. That's when the identity you've been building either holds or cracks. The same test arrives at home, at 6 p.m., when the pasta is boiling over, someone is crying, and the person you love asks a perfectly reasonable question in a tone you decide isn't.

Pressure has a specific physiology. It tightens the chest, narrows the vision, speeds up the internal monologue. In that state, the brain reaches for the fastest available response, not the best one. The fastest response is usually the old one: the sharp retort, the defensive email, the cold silence. This isn't a moral failure. It's biology. The practice isn't to eliminate the stress response but to build enough space between stimulus and response that you can choose something else even when the stakes feel high. That space grows with repetition, the same way a musician's fingers find the right notes under stage lights because they have played the piece ten thousand times in the practice room.

This is, more or less, the entire practical argument behind two very different traditions that turn out to agree completely on this one point. Marcus Aurelius's notebook was written almost entirely for moments exactly like a 4:45 p.m. Friday — he was often writing it in military camps, under real pressure, reminding himself that he couldn't control the crisis in front of him but could always control the space between the crisis and his response to it. Frankl made nearly the same claim from a completely different direction: that no external pressure, however severe, can actually reach in and choose your attitude for you. That choice is the one thing that stays yours no matter how loud the Friday gets. Neither of them was promising the pressure would feel good. They were promising that the space

between the pressure and your response is real, it's yours, and it gets wider with practice.

Aisha learned this lesson during a semester that almost broke her. Budget cuts, two resignations, an accreditation deadline, and a faculty grievance all landed in the same six weeks. She noticed herself retreating into silence, sending terse emails, avoiding the hallways where conversations might catch her. Her assistant finally said, in a tone that was half concern and half warning, You're becoming the person nobody wants to ask questions. The sentence landed like a splash of cold water. Not because it was cruel, but because it was accurate. Under pressure, she had dropped the very practices she spent years building.

The first step back wasn't a grand gesture. It was a single moment of honesty during a department meeting. She told her team what she was carrying, without oversharing, and admitted she knew she had been distant. The transparency felt awkward, like using a muscle that had atrophied. But the room shifted. A faculty member who had been avoiding her for weeks made eye contact and nodded. Another offered to take something off her plate. The wall she had been building to protect herself had also been keeping out the help she needed. That's one of the cruelest ironies of pressure: the self-protection that feels necessary is often the very thing that makes the situation worse.

Staying human under pressure doesn't mean being cheerful when the building is on fire. It means staying connected. Saying the truthful thing instead of the tactical thing. Asking for help when you need it. Laughing when something is genuinely funny, even if the timing is imperfect. Admitting you're stretched thin without making it anyone else's problem or anyone else's rescue mission. These are small acts, but they signal something important to the people around you: I'm still here. I'm not checking out. We're in this together.

There's also a private discipline here, the kind nobody sees. It involves noticing your own warning signs before they become someone else's problem. Maybe you start skipping lunch. Maybe you stop asking people about their weekends. Maybe your humor turns sharper, more cutting. These are indicators that pressure is winning, and the earlier you notice them, the easier the correction. The daily practices from earlier in this book aren't just for good days. They're diagnostic

tools for bad ones. When you notice the practice slipping, the practice itself tells you something about your state.

What helped Aisha most in those weeks was deceptively simple: slow down the first interaction of the day. When she was at her worst, she would dive straight into the fire the moment she sat down, sending emails before the coffee was brewed, and every interaction after that was slightly jagged. By contrast, when she took sixty seconds to walk the floor and say good morning to her team before opening the inbox, the entire day shifted. Not because the crisis got smaller, but because she had reconnected to the fact that there were people here, not just problems. The connection was the counterweight to the pressure.

One more truth about pressure: it reveals what you have actually internalized. If the kindness is only a surface layer, pressure will scrape it off in minutes. If the transparency is only a strategy, you'll abandon it the moment it stops feeling advantageous. But if the identity has genuinely shifted, pressure will show you that too. You'll find yourself, in the worst week of the quarter, still telling the truth, still sharing credit, still treating people like people. That's not because you're a saint. It's because you've practiced enough that the better response is now the faster response. The pressure didn't break you. It showed you who you had become.

A Life That Works Better

EVERYTHING IN THIS first part of the book was written for people, wherever they happen to be. No one lives only at work. The habits of kindness, transparency, and humor don't clock out at the end of the shift. They come home with you. They show up at the dinner table, in the group chat, at the family reunion, in the grocery store line. And that's where the deepest return on this work reveals itself.

Aisha noticed the spillover first in her marriage. The skills she had built at work, the patience and the willingness to say the true thing instead of the convenient thing, began to show up in arguments with her husband. Not perfectly, not overnight, but noticeably. She caught herself doing the thing she had taught herself to do with difficult colleagues: pausing before responding, naming what was

actually bothering her instead of firing back at the surface issue, finding a small moment of humor that could ease the tension without dismissing it.

Her husband noticed too. He asked one night how she had gotten so calm. She laughed. It's not calm, she said. It's practice.

There's something fitting about the fact that Dudeism, woven through this book, was never really about the office at all. It was about life in general — about taking it easy, staying loose, valuing your people and your leisure time over the score you're keeping. That it applies so cleanly to a book that began at the office says less about the office and more about how much of “professional” life was never actually a separate category from the rest of it. The same unclenched, unbothered posture that helps you shrug off a bad meeting is the posture that helps you shrug off a bad Tuesday at home. It was never really two different skills.

The reverse is also true. The person who is guarded and transactional at work tends to carry those patterns home. The person who withholds information to maintain control at the office often withholds in intimate relationships too. The person who uses humor as a weapon in meetings will eventually cut someone they love with the same blade. The patterns don't stay in their lane. That's why the identity shift in this chapter matters beyond the office door. Becoming the person people want to work with and becoming the person people want to live with aren't separate projects. They're the same project, appearing in different rooms.

There's a specific relief that comes with this integration. When you stop maintaining separate selves for work and home, you stop paying the psychological tax of constant code-switching. The mental effort of remembering who you're supposed to be in this meeting versus that family gathering versus this social situation is enormous, and most people don't notice the cost until it's gone. The person who has built a consistent identity around kindness, transparency, and humor walks into every room as the same person. That's not rigidity. It's integration. And it's one of the great unadvertised benefits of doing this work at all.

Health is part of the equation too. The research is clear that chronic isolation and conflict exact a physical toll. Stress hormones, sleep disruption, immune function. But beyond the research, there's the felt experience of living with less relational friction. The difference between a week full of unresolved tension and a week where you addressed the tension early and kindly isn't just emotional. It's

physical. You sleep differently. Your shoulders sit differently. You have more room in your body for the things that actually need your energy. The practices in this book are, among other things, a form of preventive healthcare.

Aisha put it this way one afternoon, in a conversation with a younger colleague who asked if all this kindness stuff actually mattered or if it was just a nice idea. She thought for a moment and said, It matters in ways you won't even notice until you do. Then she told a story she had never told at work, about a difficult period in her life, years earlier, when the habit of just showing up and being honest with people was the difference between disappearing and staying connected. She didn't tell the whole story. She told enough. The young colleague was quiet for a moment and then said, I think I understand. Aisha hoped she didn't yet, because understanding it fully would mean she had needed it, and Aisha wouldn't wish that on anyone prematurely.

The life-beyond-work benefits also show up in your relationship with yourself. There's a particular kind of self-respect that comes from knowing you handled a difficult situation the way you wanted to handle it, not the way your worst impulses suggested. That self-respect accumulates. Over time, it becomes a quiet confidence that's entirely separate from professional achievement. You stop needing other people to validate your goodness because you've watched yourself be good, repeatedly, when it was hard. That's not the kind of thing anyone can take from you, and it's not the kind of thing any job title can confer.

The point of this chapter is simple. The work of getting along with people isn't a side quest. It's not a soft skill that pads out your resume. It's the thing that makes the rest of your life more possible, more bearable, and more meaningful. When you become the person people want to work with, you also become the person people want to come home to, the person people want to call in a crisis, the person people trust with the truth. Everything else is just the scoreboard.

PART TWO

Pippi's Principle

Part Two is about problems, at work and at home, and it belongs to a nine-year-old with a horse on her porch. It covers why our minds default to obstacles, how to flip that default, a few small ways of looking that help, what to do on the days it doesn't work, and who you become when looking for the way through turns into a habit.

CHAPTER 6

The Hurdle Trap

WHY OUR BRAINS DEFAULT TO PROBLEMS

The Negativity Bias at Work

YOUR BRAIN IS a threat-detection machine. It was built that way for survival, and for most of human history it was a brilliant design: spot the rustle in the grass before you enjoy the sunset, or you don't get to enjoy another one. The brains that scanned for danger stayed alive long enough to pass their wiring down to you, and that wiring still switches on every morning, whether you asked for it or not.

The strange part is that the machine doesn't much care whether the threat is a saber-toothed cat or a stack of unopened bills on the kitchen table. It treats both the same way. Your heart rate ticks up, your focus narrows, and your thinking goes tight and defensive. It scans, finds something wrong, and hands it to you like a report you never asked for.

That's why bad news sticks and good news slides off. You can get nine compliments and one criticism in the same day, and you know perfectly well which one follows you home and keeps you up at night. That isn't because you're thin-skinned. It's because your brain is doing exactly what thousands of years of evolution trained it to do, which is to weigh the negative more heavily than the positive.

It's worth sitting with that for a moment, because it means your default isn't neutral. It's tilted. Tip a glass of water even slightly and the water runs to one side; your attention does the same, running toward the problem, the risk, the thing that might go wrong. That tilt served your ancestors well. In the world you actually live in — at the desk, in the meeting, at the family dinner table — it mostly costs you.

Marcus Aurelius noticed the same tilt nearly two thousand years ago, and wrote himself a note about it in the private journal we now call *Meditations*. If something outside you is causing you distress, he wrote, the pain isn't really coming from the thing itself but from your judgment of it, and that judgment is something you can revoke at any moment. He wasn't telling himself to stop feeling. He was telling himself that the first report from the alarm system is an interpretation, and interpretations can be checked.

Think about the last time you walked into a room full of strangers. Did your mind list the reasons it might go well, or did it quietly catalog every way it could go badly? Most of us run the second script without noticing. We're not being negative on purpose; we're running ancient software in a modern world. The software worked fine. It's the world around it that changed, and nobody updated the program.

And there's a trap inside the trap: the more you run that program, the better it gets at running. Every time you scan for what could go wrong, you sharpen the scanning. You get quicker at spotting hurdles and slower at spotting openings, because practice doesn't care which direction you point it — it simply makes you better at whatever you keep repeating.

So when I say your brain defaults to problems, I'm not insulting you; I'm describing the equipment. The real question isn't whether you have this wiring — everyone does — but whether you let it drive.

The Language of Limitation

LISTEN TO HOW people talk — not the big speeches, but the small, throwaway lines. “I can't do that.” “That won't work.” “We tried that before.” “It's just not possible right now.” They come out so fast that most people never hear themselves say them, but they aren't harmless. They don't just describe reality; they quietly build it.

When you say “I can't,” you're rarely reporting a fact about the world. You're reporting a fact about your current thinking, and most people never notice the difference. The sentence sounds like a wall, but it's usually a habit — the habit of stopping before you start, of closing the door while your hand is still on the knob.

Notice the shape of those phrases, too. They're all final. "That won't work" isn't a prediction; it's a verdict. "We tried that" isn't a history lesson; it's a lock on the door. The language of limitation doesn't so much describe the future as seal it off before the future gets a vote.

What makes it sneaky is that it usually sounds smart. It sounds experienced, like the voice of someone who's been around the block, and that's exactly why it spreads. Nobody wants to look naive, or to be the person in the meeting who suggests something that's already been tried, so people protect themselves with the safest possible sentence and say no before anyone else can.

I've watched it happen in rooms full of smart, capable people. Someone floats an idea that's rough and unfinished, the kind of thing that could go somewhere if it were given a little air — and the first response lands: "Yeah, but that won't work because of X." Not "How could we make that work?" or "What would have to be true?" Just the wall, up and finished, before the idea has taken a single breath.

It happens at kitchen tables too. "We're just not a family that talks about things." "He'll never change." "That's not who we are." Each of those sounds like a description, and each one is really a decision to stop looking.

The person who says it usually feels responsible, as if they've just saved everyone some time. What they've actually done is shut a door before anyone looked through it, and the cost comes later: the next person with an idea thinks twice before speaking, the room gets a little quieter, and over time everyone learns that the surest way to be respected is to be the one who says no first. That's how a culture of hurdles gets built — one small sentence at a time.

It works in reverse, though. Change the sentence and you change the room. I'm not suggesting you pretend every idea is gold — most aren't — but the words you reach for first decide what happens next. "That won't work" ends a conversation; "What would it take to make that work?" starts one. Same people, same situation, and a completely different afternoon.

The Book of Proverbs puts it more bluntly than any management book has managed: death and life are in the power of the tongue. Nobody expects that line to apply to a Tuesday planning meeting, but it does. And Dale Carnegie, in *How to Win Friends and Influence People*, made the same point from the other direction. His advice was never to tell someone flatly that they're wrong, because the

moment you do, they stop thinking about the idea and start defending themselves. “Yeah, but that won’t work” is exactly that, aimed at a half-finished thought. It lands as a verdict on the person who had it.

It’s worth simply listening for a while, without trying to fix anything. Catch the sentences as they leave your mouth and notice how often you reach for a wall instead of a window. You’ll probably surprise yourself, and that’s fine — you can’t change a habit you’ve never heard.

The Cost of Hurdle Thinking

WALT OWNS A hardware store in a small Midwestern town. He’s fifty-two, and he’s run the place for twenty years; it has survived three recessions, a highway reroute and a big-box store opening eight miles away. Walt isn’t a quitter — he’s a survivor. And right now he’s standing behind his counter, staring at his phone, feeling something he doesn’t have a word for.

On the screen is a competitor’s website: clean photos, easy ordering, delivery in two days. Walt has never sold a single thing online, and he looks at the site the way you might look at a language you don’t speak. He can see it’s real; he just can’t see himself in it. And so the first thought arrives, the way it always does, before he can stop it: “That won’t work for us.”

Then he starts building the case. The customers here want to touch the product. Online is for the big stores. We don’t have the people to run it, or the money. I’m too old to learn a whole new system. None of these are facts, exactly. They’re walls, and every wall he builds is one he’ll have to live behind.

The real cost isn’t the lost online sales. It’s the lost thinking. Every minute Walt spends defending his position is a minute he isn’t spending on the actual question — what would it take for my store to be found by people who never walk past my door? — which is sitting right there in front of him, hidden only because the hurdles got to him first.

DeShawn’s version of the same trap looks more professional. He runs a nine-person product team that has just missed a deadline, and in the post-mortem he does something that feels responsible: he lists every reason the project slipped. Dependencies, slow approvals, an understaffed testing phase, a vendor who dropped

the ball. It's a good list — accurate and thorough — and it's also, quietly, a dead end.

The trouble is what it did to the room. DeShawn named eight external reasons, and his team heard a message he never meant to send: the problems are outside us, and there's nothing we can do. Nobody said it out loud; the list said it for them. The next project started with the same structure, the same dependencies and the same vendor, and ended with the same result. The list had been so good it became a prediction. Walt builds walls to protect what he has, and DeShawn builds lists to explain what went wrong. Both feel like responsible adult behavior, and both are hurdle thinking in a professional suit. Progress stops at exactly the point where the mind stops asking what could work.

And the trap isn't confined to businesses. Marisol, forty-one, had wanted to learn to swim since she was a child growing up nowhere near water. Every summer the same thoughts arrived on schedule — I'm too old, it'll be embarrassing, everyone else learned as a kid — and each one was reasonable on its own. Together they made a wall she had lived behind for thirty years.

I'm not saying Walt is wrong about his constraints, or DeShawn about his delays, or Marisol about the embarrassment. They're all real, and that's exactly what makes hurdle thinking so seductive: it's almost always built on something true. The problem isn't that the hurdles are fake. It's that they get to speak first, and whatever speaks first tends to speak longest.

Sun Tzu saw this one coming too. In *The Art of War* he says that a wise commander blends considerations of advantage and disadvantage in his plans. Weighing the advantages is what makes a plan possible, and weighing the disadvantages is what lets you get out of trouble. It takes both columns. Walt has filled in one of them with great care and left the other blank, and DeShawn's list of eight reasons is the same ledger with the same empty column. Hurdle thinking isn't an excess of realism. It's bookkeeping with half the page missing.

The Pippi Paradox in Reverse

THINK ABOUT A small child you know, and watch them try something they've never done — ride a bike, whistle, climb a tree. What's missing is striking. There's no pre-meeting, no risk assessment, no list of reasons it will probably end badly.

The child just tries, falls, laughs and tries again. Nobody taught them that; it came standard.

Now fast-forward thirty years. Same human, new situation: an unfamiliar task lands in front of them, and the first reaction is almost never “Let me try.” It’s “I’ve never done this before.” A child can say that exact sentence and it’s a launching pad; an adult says it and it’s a diagnosis.

That’s the Pippi Paradox in reverse: the very thing that makes children fearless — not knowing how, not knowing what comes next, having no plan at all — is what makes adults hesitate. To a child, that’s the whole appeal. To an adult, it’s a stop sign. Somewhere between seven and thirty, the wiring flips.

Part of the reason is practice. Every year you live, you collect a longer list of things that didn’t work out. Some of those lessons are useful, and some are just scars dressed up as wisdom, but your brain files them all in the same drawer. It doesn’t check whether a lesson still applies; it simply pulls the file and hands it to you as fact.

Part of it is identity. Adults have something children don’t: a self-image to protect. A child who fails at climbing a tree is just a kid who fell out of a tree. An adult who fails at something new risks being seen as someone who doesn’t know what they’re doing, and that feels expensive in a way a scraped knee never did.

And part of it is the people around you. Children get clapped for trying; adults get advice. Tell a friend you’re thinking about starting something you’ve never done and watch how fast the warnings arrive — almost always well meant, and almost always hurdle thinking in a friendly disguise.

The good news is better than it sounds: the child isn’t gone. That instinct didn’t get deleted; it got buried under a pile of evidence, opinions and rehearsed sentences, and buried isn’t the same as gone. You’ve dug up harder things than that.

There’s a very old line about this, and it comes from the Gospel of Matthew: unless you change and become like little children, you will not enter the kingdom of heaven. You can hold whatever view of the theology you like and still see the practical point. The instruction isn’t to become childish. It’s to recover a particular kind of openness, the one that says “I’ve never done this” and means “this will be interesting.”

It starts with recognizing that the hesitation isn't always wisdom talking. Often it's forgetting — forgetting what it was like to try something with nothing but a shrug and a plan to figure it out as you went. That isn't a character flaw. It's a memory problem, and memory problems are solved by remembering.

Spotting the Trap in Real Time

IF THERE'S ONE thing in this chapter worth carrying with you, it's small enough to fit in a pocket: noticing the moment your thinking tips from possibility to obstacle. Not later, in the car on the way home, but while it's happening.

That moment usually announces itself in the body before the mind catches up. For some people it's a small tightening between the shoulder blades; for others it's a sudden drop in energy, as if the room got slightly dimmer. It can be a quick blink, a lean back in the chair, or a reflexive nod that says no while the mouth is still deciding whether to say maybe.

You won't catch it every time, and you don't need to. Most of the time you'll notice halfway through the sentence, or an hour afterward, and that still counts. What you're growing is a kind of gentle self-awareness, and it comes slowly, the way any attentiveness does.

When you do notice it, there's no need to argue with yourself or give yourself a pep talk. It's enough to recognize it, quietly and in plain words — ah, there it is — and leave it at that. The recognition alone turns the trap from something that runs you into something you can see.

It works because the hurdle thought is almost always faster than you are. It arrives before the idea has finished forming, so quickly that it feels like a fact. Recognizing it slows it down just enough to see it for what it is: a thought, old and well practiced and automatic, rather than the truth of the situation. It's the first report, and first reports are often wrong.

Dudeism has a version of this that fits on a bumper sticker: take it easy. People hear that as laziness, but what sits underneath it is exactly what's described here. The Dude doesn't fix the tension in the room. He just notices when he has started gripping, and lets go a little. Feeling the tightness between your shoulder blades and thinking "there it is" is the same thing. It doesn't solve anything. It just returns you to the person who is able to.

For a day or two, there's no need to change anything else. It's enough just to notice — in meetings, in family conversations, wherever you happen to be. Catch it once and you've done well; catch it three times and you're ahead of most people.

A word of warning, though: when you start noticing, you may feel worse before you feel better. You'll hear how often you reach for the wall and see the pattern everywhere. That isn't a sign that something is wrong. It's a sign the light has come on — and you can't tidy a room you can't see.

CHAPTER 7

Flip the Lens

THE SOLUTION-SEEKING MINDSET

Problems Are Questions in Disguise

PRIYA, THE ENGINEER from Chapter 1 whose suggestion vanished into a Slack thread, sat in a conference room months later and listened to her team list every reason the product launch had failed. She'd stopped waiting for a gap in the conversation by then; she'd started making one. Nobody said anything wrong. The pricing was off, the onboarding confused new users, the marketing missed the mark. Every item on the list was true, and every item was a dead end, because a list of reasons stays a list of reasons until somebody turns one of them into a question.

That idea runs through this whole chapter. Every problem you face is carrying a question inside it, hidden the way a coat hides a person. You see the coat, you argue with the coat, you complain about the coat — and all the while the question is standing right there underneath it, waiting to be noticed.

Take “the pricing is off.” That’s a statement, and statements close doors. Turn it into a question — what would make the price feel obviously right to the people we built this for? — and the situation hasn’t changed, but your posture has. The first asks you to defend; the second invites you to explore. Priya tried it right there in the room. She wrote the problem on the whiteboard and added a question mark at the end. Her team went quiet for a second, and then somebody said, “What if we tested three different prices before we spend another dollar on ads?” The problem hadn’t gone anywhere, but the question had given everyone somewhere to go.

It works on almost anything. “The project is behind schedule” becomes: what would need to be true to catch up without burning everyone out? “The client is unhappy” becomes: what is the client actually afraid of losing? “The team isn’t communicating” becomes: where exactly is the handoff breaking down? And “my teenager won’t talk to me” becomes: when does she talk, and what is she doing when she does? None of those questions solves anything on its own. They simply move you from standing still to walking.

That’s really all “problems are questions in disguise” means. It isn’t a slogan so much as a way of getting your mind to stop circling the obstacle and start looking for the opening, which is usually closer than you think — often just on the other side of a sentence you were too busy arguing with to finish.

Marcus Aurelius has a line on this that’s worth taping to a monitor. The impediment to action, he wrote in *Meditations*, advances action, and what stands in the way becomes the way. He was a Roman emperor with a frontier full of trouble, so he wasn’t speaking theoretically. The obstacle isn’t sitting between you and the work. Very often it is the work, and the question hidden inside it is telling you where to begin.

The “I Never Did It Before, So I Think I Can” Principle

HERE’S THE PART that sounds backwards: the people best placed to solve a problem are often the ones who’ve never solved it before. Not always, but more often than you’d guess, and it’s worth understanding why.

When you’ve done something a hundred times, you stop seeing it. You see your memory of it — the way it’s supposed to go, the steps you already know. That’s efficient, but it’s also a cage, because someone who already knows how a thing works finds it much harder to imagine it working differently. A beginner has no cage. A beginner looks at the same situation and asks the obvious question nobody else is asking, the one that sounds too simple to matter: Why are we doing it this way? Who said it had to be like this? What if we tried the thing everyone here would laugh at?

Look at what Pippi’s sentence actually says: I never did it before, so I think I can. Most of us read that and hear nonsense, because the version we were raised on runs the other way — I never did it before, so I probably can’t. Pippi’s version

is a different way of standing in the world altogether. It treats inexperience as permission rather than as a warning.

The Bible has a good picture of this in the story of David and Goliath, and it isn't the part about the stone. Before the fight, King Saul, who was the seasoned professional, put his own armor on the young shepherd: the bronze helmet, the coat of mail, the sword. David walked around in it for a moment and said he couldn't go in that, because he had never tested it. Then he took off the borrowed expertise, picked up the sling he actually knew, and went out to meet the giant. Everyone around him had a proven playbook. David's advantage was that he had one that had never been tried on this problem, and was therefore free of its assumptions.

Priya wasn't a pricing expert. She was an engineer who had built the thing, and that was exactly why she could see it. The marketing lead, who'd run a dozen launches, kept reaching for the same playbook; Priya, having none, reached for a question. The playbook could only tell him what had worked before. Priya asked what might work now.

None of this means expertise is useless. It means your expertise is a tool rather than a leash — something to use, and then set down when it starts telling you what's impossible. The most dangerous sentence in any room is the one that begins "We already tried that." Sometimes it's true. Sometimes it's just a comfortable way to stop thinking.

So the next time you catch yourself saying you've never done this, try hearing it as an opening rather than a warning. You're standing exactly where the people who already know how it works can no longer stand, and that's an advantage worth treating like one.

Going the Opposite Direction

WHEN A FIRST instinct shows up, it's worth glancing at its opposite — not because the opposite is always right, but because it's always informative. It shows you the default you were about to follow without ever having chosen it.

Say a client tells you no. The instinct is to ask what would change their mind. The opposite is to ask what would make it a clear no for you as well. That question does something unexpected: it puts you on the same side of the table, so that

instead of one of you selling and the other resisting, you're both working out whether it fits. It works between people who love each other, too. When a partner says no to your plan for the holidays, wondering together what a yes would need to look like for both of you goes a great deal further than arguing your case.

Dale Carnegie would have approved of that shift. One of his most durable observations was that the only way to get the best of an argument is to avoid it, because even the person who wins it usually loses the person. Asking what a clear no would look like isn't a clever move. It simply refuses the argument and offers a shared question in its place.

Sometimes you do have to go the opposite direction, and I mean that plainly. When everyone in the room is leaning one way, it's worth leaning the other way for a moment just to see what the view is like from there. You don't have to stay; you only have to look. Most people never do. They pick a direction and call it reality.

Sun Tzu drew a line here that has aged well. In *The Art of War* he observes that the direct approach is what you use to join battle, but it's the indirect approach that wins it. The head-on argument, the obvious fix and the standard playbook are how everyone shows up. The move nobody expected is how anything changes. It doesn't have to be clever. It just has to come from a direction the situation hadn't already been arranged to defend.

Priya's team wanted to understand why the launch had failed so they could fix the launch. The opposite direction said: stop trying to fix it. Rewrite the onboarding, test the price, and let the next version do the talking. Same team, same problem, opposite move — and suddenly there was work to do instead of blame to assign.

This isn't contrarianism for its own sake, which is just another cage facing the other way. The point is to widen your view long enough to notice the option you'd already filtered out before you even saw it. It's usually there — the one you dismissed as too odd, too simple or too obvious to say out loud — and saying it takes less cleverness than willingness: the willingness to voice what everyone is thinking and nobody is saying, to try the smaller version instead of the grand one, to be the person whose question makes the room go quiet for a second.

You won't always change direction, and you shouldn't. But once you've looked, you stop defaulting, and that's most of what matters.

Curiosity Over Certainty

CERTAINTY FEELS WONDERFUL, and it's also expensive. The moment you know something for sure, you stop looking. That's fine when you're checking the time; it's a problem when you're looking at a stalled project, a strained relationship, or a market that moved while you weren't watching.

Curiosity is certainty's opposite, and it's much lighter to carry. Curiosity says, I wonder what's really going on here. Certainty says, I know what's going on here. Only one of them leaves room for new information, and only one lets you discover you're wrong in time to do something about it.

Listen to certainty in a meeting: That'll never work with our customers. That's just how this industry works. We've tried this before. Every one of those is a full stop. Nothing comes after them, and they manage to feel responsible even as they end the conversation. Curiosity sounds different: What would have to be true for our customers to love this? Where did that industry rule come from in the first place? What was different last time? Same room, same people, entirely different energy — one keeps the doors locked in a way that feels professional, and the other quietly opens them.

Carnegie's advice on this is disarmingly simple. Become genuinely interested in other people, and ask them questions they enjoy answering. He meant it as a way to make friends, but it works just as well on a problem, because a problem usually has people inside it. The client, the stalled vendor and the colleague who keeps blocking the release all know something you don't. Curiosity is how you find out what it is.

Priya noticed certainty in herself after the launch failed. She'd walked into the post-mortem already sure what had gone wrong, and it took her a while to realize she wasn't gathering facts at all. She was collecting evidence for a verdict she'd reached before the meeting started. That's what certainty does: it turns you into a lawyer instead of a scientist.

The Book of Proverbs has a stern line about this state of mind. Do you see someone wise in their own eyes, it asks. There is more hope for a fool than for that

person. It sounds harsh until you remember what certainty does. It closes the file. The fool, at least, is still open to hearing something new, and the person who already knows how it will turn out isn't.

It's the same thing Chapter 1 asked of you with the people you've filed under "difficult." Wondering what might be going on for Dan is curiosity pointed at a person instead of a project — the same muscle, aimed somewhere new.

A scientist wants to be wrong early, because being wrong early is cheap and being wrong late isn't. So ask the question, try something small, and let the answer surprise you. Certainty is comfortable, but curiosity is useful.

None of this means having no opinion. You can hold a strong view and still stay curious about it — the view gives you direction, and the curiosity keeps you from driving off a cliff because you liked the scenery. You need both, and most of us only practice one.

Looking for the Opening

EVERY HARD SITUATION carries a few quiet questions, and you don't need a worksheet to ask them. What is this asking of us that we've been avoiding? What is it making possible that wasn't possible before? And who else could benefit if we handled it well?

Priya found herself asking them, almost by accident, after the failed launch. The situation was asking for real user testing before anything shipped — exactly the work the team had been putting off. The failure was making possible a rebuilt onboarding, shaped by the feedback they'd only been guessing at. And everyone at the company who'd been shipping on instinct and hoping for the best stood to benefit.

There's an old promise in the Gospel of Matthew that says the same thing in a different register: ask, and it will be given to you; seek, and you will find; knock, and the door will be opened. Read plainly, without the theology, it describes how openings work. They're found by people who keep asking questions, keep looking and keep knocking on doors that everyone else has already decided are shut.

That feels very different from a post-mortem. A post-mortem looks backward at the wreck; these questions look around at what's on the table now. They work on almost anything — a conversation you've been avoiding, a product that isn't

selling, a family that's drifting apart — and whatever comes up is worth noticing, especially if it sounds obvious, because the obvious is usually what everyone skipped.

It's less a method than a way of walking through the world, noticing openings where other people see walls. Live with it long enough and you stop doing it on purpose. It simply becomes the way you see.

CHAPTER 8

Small Ways of Looking

HABITS OF MIND FOR ORDINARY DAYS

Give It Five Minutes

WHEN SOMETHING GOES wrong, the first response is almost always a feeling, not a plan. A key client goes quiet for two weeks and the thought arrives fully formed: my client has stopped responding. It sounds final. It feels like a fact.

What I've learned to do is wait a few minutes before I react, and then say the same thing a different way. I have an opening in my week and a reason to call two people I've been meaning to call. Nothing about the client changed. Everything about my next move did.

Marcus Aurelius had a version of this habit, and it was surprisingly earthy. He advised looking at things stripped of their decoration. Roast meat, he reminded himself, is the dead body of a fish or a bird, and the finest wine is grape juice. He wasn't being cynical. He was practicing the plain sentence. Say what actually happened, without the story, and then decide what to do about it. The plain sentence is where the truth is. The story is where the panic lives.

This isn't pretending the problem away. The client really did go quiet, and the numbers are what they are. It just refuses to let the problem have the last word before I've had mine. And I keep the first sentence, the plain one, because it tells me what actually happened without the story I piled on top. More than once, my best decision came from looking at that plain sentence and realizing the problem was never as big as it felt, and never as small as the cheerful version pretended either.

Try it on something small first: a delayed shipment, a meeting that ran long, a toddler who refuses to put on his shoes, a cold that showed up at the worst time.

Small problems are where the habit grows, so that by the time a big one lands, the pause is already half a reflex.

Look Like a Beginner

EXPERIENCE IS A wonderful thing until it starts answering questions before you have asked them. You've seen this problem before, so you already know what won't work, and ten years of knowing can close a door in half a second.

Children ask better questions than adults, and not because they're smarter. They have nothing to protect. They're not guarding a reputation or a track record. They just want to know. Somewhere along the way we traded that for being right, and the trade wasn't as good as we thought.

So when I'm stuck, I sometimes imagine I have just walked in the door. I know nothing about the history, the budget or the last three attempts, and I'm honestly curious. What would that stranger ask? The questions sound almost naive. Why do we do it this way? Who decided this was the only option? What if we just stopped? Those are the questions that make room. The sophisticated ones tend to keep the room exactly the same size.

Dudeism, which borrows a good deal from Taoism, has always been comfortable with not knowing. The Dude never pretends to have the situation figured out. He asks what's going on, admits when he's lost, and tends to let the answer arrive. That's not a lack of ambition. It's a very relaxed form of beginner's courage.

You don't have to believe the naive questions. You only have to be willing to say one out loud. It gives everyone else permission to think the thought they were too professional to say. And you're allowed to be a beginner at any age, on any topic, at any point in your career.

Walk the Other Way for a While

WHEN MY FIRST instinct shows up, I like to look at its opposite. Not because the opposite is right, but because it's informative. It shows me the default I was about to follow without ever choosing it.

A team I know was stalled on a project that needed to move faster. The instinct was more meetings, more check-ins, more pressure. The opposite was fewer meetings, less checking, more silence, and it sounded irresponsible. But instead of dismissing it, someone asked what would have to be true for less checking to work. The answer was that the team would have to actually own the outcome. They didn't take the whole reverse. They took the part about ownership, and the project moved.

That's how it usually goes. The opposite direction is rarely the destination. It's a map. You walk all the way to the reverse so you can see the middle clearly on the way back. And it helps to let it sit overnight before you judge it, because an idea that sounds ridiculous at four in the afternoon often sounds merely unusual by morning.

Sun Tzu compared a good army to water. Water, he wrote in *The Art of War*, shapes its course according to the ground it flows over, and a skilled commander wins by adapting to whatever the opponent presents. Water doesn't argue with the hill. It doesn't need to know in advance where it's going. It goes to the reverse, finds the low ground and comes back around. That's a decent model for walking the other way for a while.

Keep Some Receipts

THIS IS THE slowest habit of the bunch, and the one people tell me they're gladdest they started. Write down the problems, and then, later, write down what turned out to be hiding inside them. A few lines is plenty. If it doesn't fit on a sticky note, it's too long.

It will feel pointless at first. After a week nothing about your life has changed, and after two it still hasn't. This isn't a habit that pays off in the first month. It pays off in the fifth year, when you have a record of every kind of problem you've faced and every kind of way through that ever worked. You're no longer starting from scratch. You're starting from yourself, three years ago, who already solved something like this and wrote it down.

Marcus Aurelius kept exactly this kind of record. *Meditations* was never meant for readers. It was a private notebook in which an emperor reminded himself of the same few lessons over and over, and opened with a list of what he had learned

from each person who had shaped him. Nobody was going to grade it. He wrote it because looking back at your own thinking is how you find out which parts of it were true.

The Bible has an oddly practical version of the same thing. When the Israelites crossed the Jordan, Joshua told them to take twelve stones from the riverbed and set them up on the far side, so that when their children asked what the stones meant, there would be a story to tell. It's a stack of receipts. A crossing that felt impossible while it was happening becomes, on the other side, a pile of rocks with a story attached.

One rule: be honest about the hard part. If the problem was scary, say it was scary. If it made you want to quit, write that down too. A sanitized problem makes for a useless lesson.

There's no system here and no schedule, and that's deliberate. A few minutes now and then, a look back when you feel like it, and if you fall off for a month you just start again. Habits with penalties don't survive, as anyone who has tried a January workout plan knows. There's something quietly powerful about a notebook full of problems that stopped being problems. Not because they went away, but because you got better at seeing what they were hiding. The notebook is just where you keep the receipts.

CHAPTER 9

When It Doesn't Work

RECOVERING FROM SETBACKS AND DOUBT

The Setback Is Not the Verdict

RAFAEL SAT AT his kitchen table in Chicago with a cold cup of coffee and a rejection email open on his laptop. Third time, same client, different pitch. He'd spent two weeks on that presentation, and now the words "we have decided to go in another direction" sat on the screen like a judge's ruling. His savings were running low. His hand hovered over the reply button, and what he wanted to type was: maybe I'm not cut out for this.

That sentence was the real trap — not the rejection, but the sentence. A rejected pitch is an event. "I'm not cut out for this" is a verdict. One happens to you; the other you hand down to yourself, and then you serve it.

The difference matters more than almost anything else in this chapter. A failed attempt is information about a moment; a failed identity is a story about a person. The first is temporary and specific, the second permanent and total. Rafael hadn't failed. A pitch had — and those aren't the same thing, however identical they feel at eleven at night.

The brain doesn't help, because it likes verdicts. A verdict is clean. It means you can stop trying and rest, which is why the slide from "this didn't work" to "I don't work" happens so fast you barely notice it, and why giving up can feel almost like peace.

What helps is keeping the failure where it belongs. Name what actually went wrong, specifically — even uncomfortably specifically. "My pitch missed the budget they hinted at in the first call." "I sent it on a Friday." "I led with process

instead of outcomes.” None of those sentences contains the words “I am,” and that’s the point: the failure stays in the thing you did, and out of who you are.

Rafael did it with a pen rather than a laptop. He wrote three lines about what had missed, and underneath them one more: the version of the pitch he’d send if he got a fourth chance. It took twenty minutes and felt terrible, and it turned a verdict back into an event — something that could be worked on.

It’s tempting to skip this because it feels like spin, but it’s the opposite. Spin would be pretending the pitch was great. This is looking straight at the miss and refusing to let it write your biography.

Marcus Aurelius, who lost battles as well as won them, wrote himself a note on exactly this. If you fail to do everything by your own best principles, he says in *Meditations*, do not be disgusted or discouraged or give up. When you have stumbled, return again, and be glad if most of what you do is worthy of a human being. The point isn’t to punish yourself for the miss. It’s to come back to yourself quickly, which is a different and much shorter journey.

The Relapse into Hurdle Thinking

YOU’LL SLIDE BACK. I want to say that plainly, because otherwise you’ll slide back, decide you’ve failed at the whole thing, and give up. Relapse isn’t the opposite of progress; it’s part of what progress actually looks like.

It usually goes something like this. You’ve been looking for openings for weeks and things are moving. Then a bad week arrives, and somewhere in the middle of it you hear your own voice say, “See, this never works for me.” The strange part is how true it sounds — like something you’ve always known.

That’s the tell. Genuine reflection is curious; relapse is certain. When your thinking suddenly becomes very sure of itself and very bleak, you’re usually not having an insight. You’re having a slide.

For me, the slide shows up in the body before it reaches my thoughts. The shoulders creep toward the ears, the breath gets shallow and high, the jaw sets. Mine is a particular tightness across the back of the neck, as if someone were pressing a thumb there. When I notice that certainty creeping in and feel the thumb, I know what’s happening. It isn’t a revelation. It’s a relapse, and a relapse doesn’t call for a big decision.

What helps most is not arguing with the thought, or trying to out-debate it, but simply holding it more lightly — treating it as weather rather than a verdict. I'm in a hurdle-thinking patch right now. Weather passes. Verdicts don't.

Rafael found his own version. He kept a note on his phone called "Neck Days," and whenever he caught the certainty he wrote down the date and a line about what had set it off. After six weeks he had eleven entries, and nine of them began with a money worry. That wasn't a character flaw. It was a pattern, and a pattern is something you can plan around.

The aim was never to stop sliding altogether. It's to notice the slide while you're still near the top of the hill, before you've built a whole story at the bottom.

The Book of Proverbs, which isn't known for sentimentality, says the same thing in a single line: the righteous fall seven times and rise again. Notice what it counts as the mark of a good person. It isn't that they never fall. It's that they get up, and go on getting up, and treat the falling as an ordinary part of the walk.

The Naysayers Around You

SOME PEOPLE IN your life won't want you to change. They won't put it that way, of course. They'll say they're being realistic, or just looking out for you — and then they'll list every reason your idea won't work, in order, with citations.

Darnell is a barber in his early forties who decided to host a small Saturday workshop for young men in his neighborhood, teaching them to cut hair and to handle a job interview. He'd never run anything like it. When he mentioned it to a couple of old friends, one of them laughed and asked who was going to pay for the folding chairs.

That question is a hurdle dressed up as a practical concern. It sounds responsible, but it's really a stop sign with better manners.

The mistake most of us make with naysayers is trying to win them over. We bring data and plans; we want their approval before we begin. But approval isn't fuel. It's a bonus, and if you wait for it, you'll never leave the driveway.

Dale Carnegie spent an entire chapter of *How to Win Friends and Influence People* on why you can't win an argument, and he quoted an old rhyme to make the point: a man convinced against his will is of the same opinion still. Darnell's

friend was never going to be talked into believing in folding chairs. The only thing that could change his mind was the workshop itself.

So Darnell stopped presenting the idea and started showing the thing. The first workshop had six young men, three borrowed chairs and no budget; by the fourth Saturday there were twelve. He never did win the argument with his friend, and he didn't need to. The chairs turned up in the end, because a parent donated them.

Epictetus, who knew a great deal about being underestimated, had advice for exactly this moment. If you want to improve, he told his students, be content to be thought foolish and stupid. It's one of the more freeing sentences in all of Stoicism. The people around you may well think you're foolish for trying, and that's allowed. It's the price of trying anything new, and it's a far smaller price than never trying at all.

There's a second kind of naysayer, and this one is harder. They aren't being practical at all; they're frightened. Your trying makes them uncomfortable, because it quietly asks why they stopped. That isn't yours to fix, but it helps to recognize it, even if only privately, so you don't mistake their fear for evidence about your idea.

And, to be fair, sometimes the naysayer is right about a detail. The budget really is thin; the timing really is bad. So listen for the detail, take it, and leave the verdict behind. "You'll never pull this off" contains no usable information. "You haven't thought about where the chairs will come from" contains one useful fact, and that's worth keeping.

You're allowed to outgrow a conversation without outgrowing the person. Sometimes you simply stop bringing that topic to that table.

It's worth remembering that even the Gospels record this. When Jesus came home to Nazareth, the people who had known him since he was a child had a hard time taking him seriously, and he remarked that a prophet is honored everywhere except in his own hometown. The people who knew you before you started are the ones who find it hardest to believe you've changed. It isn't personal. It's proximity.

Borrowing Pippi's Bravery on Hard Days

SOME DAYS YOU won't feel brave. I'd rather be honest about that than pretend a change of outlook makes the hard days disappear. There will be mornings when you look at the thing you committed to and genuinely don't think you can — not as a figure of speech, but as a real, physical no.

On those mornings you don't need a new way of thinking. You need a loan: bravery borrowed from someone who isn't frightened right now, and spent before it runs out.

For a lot of people, the lender is a friend — someone who believes in you more than you do that day. You call and say the true sentence, "I don't think I can do this today," and they say back the sentence you can't yet say to yourself. That isn't weakness. It's leaning on the people you actually have.

The Bible has a clear-eyed line about why this works. Two are better than one, says Ecclesiastes, because if either of them falls, the other can lift up their friend — and pity the one who falls and has no one to help. Asking for the loan isn't weakness. Scripture, at least, treats it as the ordinary way people get back on their feet.

For others, the lender is a story — someone who did the thing without the credentials, without permission, without the fear having gone away first. Someone with mismatched stockings and no recipe and a cake that needed baking anyway. The point of borrowing from her isn't to feel inspired. It's to notice that the feeling you're waiting for, the one where you're finally ready, was never actually required. She didn't have it either. She just went first.

Borrowed bravery tends to look very small in practice. Not the whole project, but the first email, the opening paragraph, the phone call — done imperfectly, before the feeling arrives. More often than not, the feeling turns up somewhere in the middle of the doing. It almost never comes first.

Darnell had a morning like that before his first workshop. He stood in the empty room with his three chairs and seriously considered calling it off. He didn't feel ready; he felt foolish. What he did instead was unlock the door and switch on the lights, which took about eleven seconds — and then he was committed, because the room was open and someone might walk in.

The bravery was on loan. The eleven seconds were his.

Trying Again, Lighter

THE LAST PART of recovering is learning to read results differently. Most of us read a bad result as a stop sign. It's gentler, and more accurate, to read it as a measurement — a number on a dial, telling you what to adjust next time.

It's the same difference between a verdict and an event, only now facing forward. Every attempt tells you what worked, what didn't, and something you didn't know before you started. If you can name all three, the attempt wasn't wasted, however it turned out.

Rafael started asking himself a single question after each rejection: what's the one thing I'd change? Not five things — one. After the third rejection from that client he wrote, "I pitched features. They wanted to know what would happen to their workload afterward." That one sentence changed how he wrote every pitch after it. Nothing about his talent had changed; only the reading had.

One change matters more than five because five is a renovation, and renovations rarely get done. One change actually happens before the next attempt, and what keeps you going is the next attempt happening soon, not the next attempt being perfect.

Sun Tzu had a view on speed that fits neatly here. In *The Art of War* he says that he has heard of clumsy haste in war, but never seen a cleverly prolonged campaign. The same holds for attempts. The long, careful, waiting-until-it's-perfect attempt is the one that drains everything. The quick, rough, learn-as-you-go attempt is the one that keeps you going long enough to get it right.

There's a trap on the other side as well. Adjusting endlessly without ever sending anything out isn't learning; it's hiding in the workshop, polishing. Real learning means sending the thing into the world and letting it come back a little bruised. Someone who sends ten rough attempts in a month learns far more than someone who sends one perfect attempt in a year — and has ten chances at a yes, which is the rougher, more honest arithmetic behind most overnight successes.

You're not looking for a verdict on your worth. You're looking for the next reading on the dial.

The Dude would recognize this. A bad roll is a bad roll, and nobody sensible concludes from a gutter ball that they were never meant to bowl. They pick up

the next ball, and if they're the Dude, they have a drink and take it easy. Trying again lighter doesn't mean caring less. It means holding the result loosely enough that it can't flatten you.

CHAPTER 10

Becoming the Solution-Seeker

LIVING THE CAN-DO IDENTITY

From Technique to Temperament

THERE COMES A point in any practice when you stop reaching for the tool and the tool becomes part of your hand. The carpenter doesn't think about the hammer; the cook doesn't measure the salt. And someone who has spent long enough looking for openings stops asking which approach to use and simply sees the way through, often before anyone else in the room.

There's nothing magical about that shift. It's ordinary, and it's earned, the way calluses form on a guitarist's fingers — through repetition so steady that the skin forgets it was ever soft. You live with the small habits of the last few chapters until one day you notice you've skipped the habit entirely and gone straight to the answer. That skipped step is what this chapter is about.

Marcus Aurelius understood this well. Your mind, he wrote in *Meditations*, will take on the color of whatever you most often think about, because the soul is dyed by its thoughts. Technique is the dye going on. Temperament is the fabric after enough washes. You don't have to believe the sentence for it to work. You only have to keep thinking it long enough that it stops being a sentence and becomes a color.

Technique is what you do when you remember. Temperament is what you do when you forget to remember and still do the right thing. The difference sounds small, but it isn't: technique might get you through a hard meeting, while temperament gets you through a hard decade.

Aisha, whose story you met in Chapter 5, put it better than I can. She said she no longer catches herself listing the reasons something won't work, because she simply doesn't think that way anymore. Her mind goes to the possibility first — not because she trained it to, but because she wore the old paths down to nothing and the new ones became the path of least resistance.

You'll know you've crossed over when a friend brings you a problem and you feel a small spark of interest instead of a small weight of dread. That spark isn't naivety. It's a sign your default has changed, and that the hurdle has become a doorway — which is, after all, far more interesting than a wall.

It isn't a single event, either. It's a slow handing over. At first the practice owns you; eventually you own it; and then one day you forget there was ever a difference.

The Opposite Direction Life

MOST LIVES ARE shaped by the gravitational pull of what everyone else is doing. People pick the career that sounds safe, take the route everyone takes, ask the question everyone asks — and then wonder, years later, why the view looks exactly like everyone else's.

Living in the opposite direction isn't contrarianism for sport. It's noticing when the crowd is walking toward a cliff and quietly stepping to one side. Sometimes the right choice looks strange from the outside, and that's fine. Strange is often just the shape of right, seen from an angle nobody bothered to look from.

You already know how to do this; it's mostly a matter of trusting it. When everyone in your industry is cutting prices, you might raise yours. When everyone is chasing more clients, you might go deeper with fewer. When everyone is adding features, you might take one away and make the rest excellent. When everyone you know is filling every evening, you might leave one empty. The opposite direction isn't always right, but it's always worth a couple of minutes of honest thought before you dismiss it.

The Apostle Paul gave the instruction that most people quote without noticing how practical it is: do not be conformed to the pattern of this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind. In the language of this book, that's

the opposite direction life. Not rebellion, exactly — more a quiet refusal to let the crowd choose your default.

I watched this play out in a bakery that was dying. The owner was surrounded by competitors thirty years younger, with faster ovens and slicker marketing, and everyone told her to modernize. She went the other way. She slowed down and started baking one thing — a single loaf, made by a method that took two days — and charged four times what the chain stores did. Within a year she had a line out the door and a waiting list no marketing budget could have bought. She didn't beat the competition by becoming them. She beat them by becoming more fully herself.

Living this way asks for a certain tolerance for looking foolish in the short term. People will raise an eyebrow; someone will tell you that's not how it's done. Let them. The how-it's-done crowd is always the last to notice when how-it's-done has stopped working. You're allowed to choose the path through the grass that has no footprints on it yet — and when the main road is clear and crowded, that's often exactly your cue.

Teaching It Forward

THE WAY YOU meet problems isn't a private possession. It leaks. It changes a room before you say a word, and the moment you stop sighing at a problem and start leaning toward it, the people around you feel quietly permitted to do the same.

That's how teams change — not through a memo or a poster in the break room, but through one person who won't list every reason something is impossible. It's contagious in the best way. People notice that the sky didn't fall when you tried the new thing, and then they try their own, and then someone else does.

Families work the same way. A parent who asks "What could we try?" instead of "That'll never work" raises children who ask what they could try for the rest of their lives. That's a gift you can't wrap, and it keeps growing; it gets handed down to grandchildren you may never meet.

Communities respond, too. When one neighbor organizes the street cleanup instead of complaining that nobody does anything, other neighbors turn up with

brooms. When one person at the town council meeting asks what a version of this that works might look like, the temperature of the whole room shifts by a few degrees.

None of this needs a stage. You teach it mostly through your reactions — when someone brings you a half-formed idea and you meet it with curiosity instead of critique, or when a colleague panics and you say, “Okay, what are our options?” in a voice that suggests there are some. That calm is most of the lesson.

Dale Carnegie has a principle that belongs here: let the other person feel that the idea is theirs. It may be the most underrated piece of leadership advice ever printed, and it’s the natural companion to meeting someone’s stuck problem with a question rather than an answer. When you respond with curiosity instead of a solution, they arrive at the answer themselves. They leave with the idea, and with the confidence that goes with it, and that’s what actually gets passed on.

People will test it, too. Someone will bring you their favorite reason why nothing works. There’s no need to argue — arguing only proves you’re thinking about the reason as well. It’s usually enough to wonder aloud with them what would have to be true for it to work, and then watch their face. That’s how it spreads.

You don’t need a hundred people around you to stop defaulting to no. You need two or three, and then those two or three reach a few more. That’s how any culture changes: slowly, then all at once, starting from one person who wouldn’t stop asking what else might be possible. Be that person in your own small circle — not loudly, not preachily, just steadily. The way you carry yourself will teach more than any speech.

The Never-Done-It-Before Bucket List

MOST BUCKET LISTS are about places: see the pyramids, watch the northern lights, stand on a beach in Bali. They’re lovely goals, but they tend to miss one of the richest ingredients of a life, which is doing things you have absolutely no idea how to do.

So I keep a different list, a never-done-it-before list. Everything on it is something I have no experience in — no training, no credentials, no obvious reason to think I’d be any good at it — and that’s precisely why it belongs there. The inexperience is the invitation, not the disqualification.

Some of the entries are big: learning an instrument at forty-eight, speaking in public when every cell in my body would rather do anything else, writing a book with no writing experience, which is exactly the kind of thing a list like this is for.

There's a Bible story I keep near this list. Caleb, at eighty-five, walks up to Joshua and says, more or less, that he's as strong today as he was at forty, and that he'd like to be given the hill country. It was the difficult one, full of giants. He didn't ask for a comfortable retirement. He asked for the hard hill, at an age when everyone expected him to sit down. If a man of eighty-five can put a mountain on his list, learning an instrument at forty-eight isn't really a stretch.

Other entries are small. Cooking a dish from a cuisine you can't pronounce. Taking a class in something you'll almost certainly be bad at. Walking into the shop you've passed a thousand times without ever knowing what it sells. The size doesn't matter much; it's the newness that does the work.

The only thing the list asks of you is willingness. You don't need to be good. Willingness gets you through the first awkward hour, and skill, if it ever comes, is a bonus. Most people simply give up before willingness has had a chance to do its job.

It's best to start with one entry — not the biggest, just something you could try this month with a couple of hours and a little courage. Do it badly. Notice that nothing catastrophic happened, and that you're curious about doing it again. Then pick another. Six months later, look at how many things have moved from never to once. The list won't shrink; it'll grow, because the more new things you do, the more new things occur to you. That isn't a problem. It's exactly the spiral you were hoping for.

Some people will ask why you bother. You can explain, or you can just keep going and let your life be the answer.

A Lifelong Posture, Not a Destination

THERE'S NO FINISH line for this, and I'd like to be clear about that. There's no graduation day when you become an official solution-seeker and never have to think about it again. Identity doesn't work like a plaque on the wall. It's a set of small choices, made over and over, that eventually become a shape other people recognize in you.

Some mornings you'll wake up and feel the old gravity. The reasons will be sitting right there on the edge of the bed, ready to be listed. That doesn't mean you've lost anything; it means you're a person with a human brain. What matters is the next ten minutes, not what showed up in the first three.

It helps to think in terms of posture rather than pose. A pose is what you do when someone's watching. A posture is what you look like from across the room when you aren't trying at all. What you want is the posture — to be the kind of person who, when things get hard, reaches for possibility without having to remind yourself to. That person is built slowly, out of thousands of small moments of choosing the brighter path.

The posture has seasons, too. Some seasons you'll feel sharp and clear and ready; in others you'll just be keeping your head above water. Both are fine. The posture doesn't require peak form. It only asks that you don't abandon it when the season gets heavy — that you keep asking what could work, even when you don't feel like it, and especially then.

It isn't about being relentlessly positive, either. It's about being relentlessly interested. Positive people sometimes ignore real problems; interested people look straight at them and get curious about the seams. Optimism tends to run out of fuel. Curiosity has a much bigger tank.

Dudeism chose the word abide for a reason. Abiding isn't winning, and it isn't ascending. It's the verb for staying with a thing, patiently and without fuss, through whatever weather arrives. It fits the posture in this chapter better than any sports metaphor. You're not aiming for a finish line. You're aiming to keep being the person who looks for the door, and to let that be enough.

Eventually, the posture becomes the way your friends describe you to other people: she always finds a way through; he just sees things differently. They won't know how you got there, and that's fine. You'll know it was years of small choices nobody watched.

It's also what you leave behind. Long after you've stopped wondering whether you're any good at this, the people around you will carry the shape of how you handled difficulty, and pass it on the way these things always get passed on — quietly, by example. That's the real reward. Not that you never struggled, but that you struggled in a way that taught other people how.

There's no completion, only continuation. You keep showing up, keep reaching for the possibility before the problem, keep doing things you've never done — one ordinary day at a time.

Conclusion

THE ADVANTAGE WAS ALWAYS YOURS

What You Now Know

YOU'VE LEARNED THAT the quiet cost of getting it wrong isn't just a missed promotion or a tense meeting or a sibling who has gone quiet. It's the slow erosion of trust, the conversations that stop happening, the ideas that never surface because someone doesn't feel safe enough to speak. That cost was real before you understood it, and now you can see it coming.

You've also learned that the fix isn't complicated. Kindness, transparency, humor — these aren't lofty ideals or soft skills to sprinkle on top of your real work. They're the work. They're how you build a team, a family, a circle of friends that tells you the truth, shares the credit, and has your back when things go sideways. They're how you become the person others want in the room when it matters.

You've learned something else, too, and it may be the one that surprises you most. The hurdle list in your head isn't a fact about the world. It's a habit, an old and once-useful one that has outlived its job. Problems are questions in disguise. Inexperience is a permission slip, not a debt. And the sentence that once sounded like a warning — I've never done this before — can be heard as an opening instead.

You may have started this book wondering why some people seem to move through their days, at work and at home, with so much less friction than others. The answer isn't charisma you're born with or tricks you memorize. It's a set of choices you make in ordinary moments — the message you could have fired off cold, the credit you could have grabbed, the joke you could have made at someone's expense. Each of those choices adds up.

None of it was ever about scripts to recite or formulas to follow. It's about a way of being that you live with until it feels like breathing: starting the day with a few people in mind, saying hard things without breaking anyone, finding your way back when you stumble. You know that repair isn't weakness, and that humor, used with care, is one of the quickest roads to trust. And you have a second way of seeing, for the moments when the problem in front of you isn't a person at all: asking what could work before you list what won't.

The One Thing to Remember

IF YOU FORGET everything else in this book, hold on to this: people remember how you made them feel long after they forget what you said or did. That's not a platitude — it's the heart of the whole thing. A friend who felt heard in a hard conversation will show up for you six months later. A younger colleague who saw you share credit will do the same when they lead. A family that laughed together through a brutal week will stay closer than one that only ground through it.

Everything in these pages serves that one truth. You don't need to be the smartest person in the room, or win every argument, or command every project. You need to be the person who makes others feel capable, respected and a little lighter. Do that consistently, and doors open that no strategy could force.

So carry this with you: kindness isn't a performance, transparency isn't a weakness, and humor isn't a distraction. They're among the deepest forms of respect you can offer another human being. When you show up that way, people don't just work with you or live alongside you — they want to.

Most of all, you know now that this was never about becoming someone else. It's about setting down armor you didn't need and letting the person you already are show up more fully. The advantage was never in becoming a different person. It was in letting the best parts of you do the work they were always meant to do.

None of this started with me, and it's worth saying so plainly at the end. Sun Tzu understood that the best battles are the ones you never have to fight. Epictetus, a former slave, taught that peace begins with knowing what is yours to control, and Marcus Aurelius spent his nights in a private notebook trying to live by it. Viktor Frankl came through the worst of circumstances convinced that meaning is a choice. Dale Carnegie noticed that people mostly want to feel heard. The

Gospels insist that how you treat the person with the least power in the room is the treatment that counts. Dudeism suggests that most of it goes down easier if you stop gripping so hard. And a fictional nine-year-old decided the cake didn't need to know she had never baked one.

Different centuries, different continents, entirely different stakes — and somehow they all arrive in the same place. Be decent. Pay attention. Hold on loosely. Try the thing you've never tried. Let the people around you matter more than the point you're trying to win. I didn't invent any of that. I just kept noticing it was true, everywhere I looked, including at a folding table in a break room on a Tuesday.

The Ripple Effect

NOBODY TEACHES THIS in a conference room, but the moment you change how you meet the world, other people notice. They can't always name it. They watch you take a bad break without folding, ask a question that stops a room, try something you had no business trying and somehow land on your feet — and a small door opens in their own minds.

You've probably seen it happen already. A coworker who used to list every reason a project would fail starts floating half-baked ideas. Your child, who used to say "I can't," starts saying "Let me try." A friend who has been stuck for years calls to say she's finally going to do the thing. She doesn't say why, and she doesn't have to. You already know.

Permission is contagious. When one person goes first, the people around them suddenly have evidence that it can be done — not a theory or a podcast, but an actual human being they know, walking into the unknown and coming back with a story instead of a scar.

That's the ripple. You can't control it or schedule it. It happens because you showed up differently, and showing up differently is louder than any sermon.

Think about the people in your life who are stuck right now — not the ones who are content there, but the ones quietly waiting for someone to go first. You might be that someone. You probably already are.

The world doesn't need a million Pippis; it needs a few, willing to walk into the kitchen with no recipe and see what happens. When one of them bakes a cake, the

neighbors smell it, and before long somebody else is in their own kitchen, cracking eggs they've never cracked before. That's how a culture changes — not from the top down, but kitchen to kitchen, person to person.

Two Small Beginnings

IF YOU'D LIKE somewhere to start, here are two small things, and both fit inside a single day. One is about a person; the other is about a problem.

Big change rarely begins with a grand plan. It begins with one small, sincere act. Tomorrow, before the meetings start and the messages pile up, think of one person — a teammate, a boss, a neighbor, someone in your own family — and let them know you noticed them.

Not praise for praise's sake; something true. Tell a coworker you saw how well they handled a hard call last week. Tell your sister you've been thinking about something she said. Thank someone for the thing that quietly made your day easier. Ask about their life because you actually want to know. It takes almost no time, and it only works if you mean it.

The point isn't to tick off a kindness. It's to interrupt the autopilot that tells you to keep your head down and mind your own list — the same autopilot that kept you guarded for so long. Then notice what happens: how they respond, how you feel, how the rest of your morning goes. That small moment is a doorway back to the person you've decided to be.

The second can wait until evening, and it's about a problem rather than a person.

Think of one thing in your life you've been calling impossible. Not the biggest one, or the dream that frightens you most — the smaller one. The project you keep postponing, the conversation you keep rehearsing, the little idea you've filed under "someday."

Write down, in one honest sentence, the real reason you've been saying no — not the polite version you give at dinner parties, but the one underneath. Read it back, and notice how much of it is a hurdle and how much is a question waiting to be asked.

Then ask that question — what would have to be true for this to work? — and write down the first answer that comes. It doesn't have to be brilliant, only real.

And before you go to sleep, do one small thing that points toward it: send the email, make the call, open the document.

You'll be tempted to skip this, and to feel that understanding the idea is enough. It isn't, and you know it; that's why you're still reading. Reading about a way of living and living it are different things, and the second grows the way everything in this book grows — not in a grand declaration, but in small, unglamorous moments that nobody else ever sees.

A Final Word

THERE'S A REASON a nine-year-old in mismatched stockings keeps turning up in these pages. She isn't brave because she knows more. She's brave because she knows less. There's no folder in her head labeled "reasons this will fail" — just a question and a kitchen.

You had that once, before the meetings and the mortgages and the years of being told that cautious and wise were the same thing. Somewhere along the way you traded it for a voice that was always ready with the downside. You can get it back — not by forgetting what you know, but by remembering what you don't, and letting the beginner's question breathe for a moment before the expert's answer shuts the door.

The next unknown is already on its way. Maybe it's a job that doesn't exist yet, or a relationship that doesn't quite make sense, or a project every sensible person in your life will tell you not to start. Maybe it's just a Tuesday when everything feels stuck. When it comes, there's a plain sentence worth saying to yourself, in your own voice:

I never did it before, so I think I can.

That's the fifth principle, and it's the one that puts the other four to work.

There will still be days when all of this feels harder than it should — when someone snaps at you, when humor feels risky, when kindness seems like too much effort. Show up anyway. Not perfectly, just genuinely. One honest conversation, one shared laugh, one moment of openness can turn a bad day around, and even when it doesn't, it keeps you anchored to who you want to be.

The world doesn't need more people with polished strategies and guarded hearts. It needs people who tell the truth, share what they have, and make a room a little warmer just by being in it. That was always available to you. It never required a title, a degree or anyone's permission — only a decision, and by reading this far you've already made it. Now live it: not someday, when things settle down, but in the middle of the messy, imperfect, often frustrating reality of ordinary life. That's where the advantage was always waiting — in the version of you who shows up tomorrow morning and says hello like you mean it.

One more old idea has been running quietly underneath this whole book, and it belongs at the very end. It comes from one of the last scenes of *The Big Lebowski*, and Dudeism took it as something close to a motto, because three words manage to say the whole thing. Not that the Dude wins, or figures it all out, or gets what he deserves. Just that he stays. He keeps showing up, decent and unbothered, whatever the day throws at him. You don't have to win every room or impress everyone in it. You only have to be kind, honest, a little bit funny, and every now and then willing to bake a cake you have no recipe for — one ordinary Tuesday at a time.

The Dude abides.

Further Reading

THE IDEAS IN this book lean on older and wiser voices. Quotations in these pages are paraphrased from memory and from translation; if something caught your attention, these are the places to read it properly.

- Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations*. Written around 170–180 AD as a private notebook. The translation by Gregory Hays, Modern Library, 2002, is especially readable.
- Epictetus, *Discourses* and *Enchiridion*, also known as *The Handbook*, recorded by his student Arrian in the early second century. Robin Hard's translation, Oxford World's Classics, collects both.
- Sun Tzu, *The Art of War*. Fifth century BC. The classic English translation is Lionel Giles's, 1910.
- Viktor E. Frankl, *Man's Search for Meaning*. First published in German in 1946; English edition 1959.
- Dale Carnegie, *How to Win Friends and Influence People*. Simon & Schuster, 1936.
- The Bible. Passages drawn on in this book come from the Books of Proverbs, Ecclesiastes and Joshua, the story of David and Goliath in 1 Samuel, the Gospels of Matthew and Luke, and Paul's Letter to the Romans.
- Oliver Benjamin and Dwayne Eutsey, *The Abide Guide: Living Like Lebowski*. Ulysses Press, 2011. The founding text of Dudeism, which borrows freely from Lao Tzu's *Tao Te Ching*.
- Joel and Ethan Coen, *The Big Lebowski*. Film, 1998.
- Astrid Lindgren, *Pippi Longstocking*, 1945, and *Pippi Goes on Board*, 1946.
- Mary Schmich, "Advice, like youth, probably just wasted on the young." *Chicago Tribune*, 1 June 1997. Set to music by Baz Luhrmann as "Everybody's Free to Wear Sunscreen," 1999.
- Hanlon's razor, attributed to Robert J. Hanlon, first appeared in print in Arthur Bloch's *Murphy's Law Book Two*, 1980.

*People remember how you made them feel long after they forget
what you said or did.*

This is not a book of tricks. It is a plain account of how I believe people should treat one another: with kindness that has a spine, honesty that arrives before anyone has to ask for it, generosity that does not keep count, and enough humor to remember that none of us has it figured out.

It starts from a simple belief: that most of what goes wrong between people, at work, at home and everywhere in between, comes from distance rather than malice, and that most of it can be mended by paying attention, saying the true thing gently, and being willing to try what you have never tried. Not because it pays off, but because it is a better way to spend a life.